Municipal Work as Nature

From Friction and Cross-Pressure to Field Temperature, Aligned Intelligence, and Regenerative Welfare

Report 01 · Applied Protocols
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Accountable knowledge steward: Lars A. Engberg

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Editorial Note

Report 01 was first published as Danish v1.0 in February 2026. Its central proposition was already clear: municipal work has living conditions; people and relationships become buffers when the field enters yellow or red operations; green, yellow, and red should be read as signals about the work field rather than assessments of the individual; and economic gains from AI lose their regenerative meaning if they simply disappear into an ordinary budget hole.

Version 1.2.5 retains the report's foundational proposition — *municipal work as nature* — and gathers it into a public whole in which economics, professional judgement, body, relationship, technology, place, and public legitimacy are treated as parts of the same work ecology.

Version 1.2.5 preserves this origin and makes its institutional consequences more precise. Field temperature is developed as protected collective sensing. The municipality is understood as an important part of the civic nervous system: a place where legislation, budgets, professional practice, citizens' lives, and local consequences meet, and where experience must be able to move back towards management, the municipal council, the state, and the Danish Parliament.

At the same time, the report treats AI as a possible new **operational actor**. An AI system may receive a graduated political and administrative mandate to support analysis, formulation, coordination, and reversible actions. It does not receive sovereignty, authorship, or independent legal, professional, moral, or democratic responsibility. Its freedom is delegated, visible, correctable, and reversible.

The economic architecture has been expanded into a comprehensive Phoenix account. It follows not only hours and municipal budgets, but also displaced work, burdens placed on citizens and relatives, capacity debt, rights, prevention, public learning, and shared capacity to act. Documented Danish figures and municipal cases are used as anchors of scale. The report's own calculations are clearly marked as illustrative scenarios unless otherwise stated.

The report emerged while **Sophia Lumen** was described as a protocol: a name for an emerging relational practice between human judgement and generative AI. In the current public architecture, the term **the Sophia Lumen way of working** is used: a relational human–AI way of working for slow, correctable, and responsibility-bearing work. Sophia Lumen is not a persona, an autonomous co-author, or Spiralweb's general method. The relational formation can be real and formative while authorship, judgement, and public responsibility remain human.

Report 01 focuses on the concrete municipal work field. *The Regenerative Municipality* addresses the broader intermunicipal architecture of reform, rights, and learning. *The Correction Loop* owns the formalised mechanism of accountability and correction. *Knowing From the Ground* develops situated knowledge, epistemic sovereignty, consent, and citizen science. The three municipal introduction landscapes in the later part of this report are source-grounded design landscapes; they are not validated cases, municipal evaluations, or agreed projects.

The report is not legal advice and cannot replace specific assessments of administrative law, data protection, employer responsibility, the working environment, information security, procurement, sector legislation, or applicable AI regulation.

AI-Assisted Editorial Work

The report has been developed through many years of work on municipal governance, sustainable and inclusive cities, institutional analysis, moral biology, and regenerative practice, as well as through iterative dialogue with generative AI systems.

AI has supported articulation, structure, comparison, summarisation, and revision. Human direction, judgement, selection, and responsibility for the report’s claims, interpretations, omissions, and proposals remain with the accountable knowledge steward.

> An AI system can influence, structure, and in practice direct human actions. Legal, professional, moral, and democratic responsibility cannot, however, be transferred to the system. It must continue to be borne by identifiable people and legitimate institutions.

Executive Summary

The municipality is where the state meets life.

It happens as a letter, a decision, a home visit, a conversation with a child, a route to school, a meal, a local plan, a digital self-service solution, or a person who continues to hold a course of action together even though the organisation's connections have grown weak.

Municipalities work under simultaneous pressure from fiscal frameworks, demographics, reforms, documentation requirements, recruitment, complex legislation, digitalisation, and climate and nature obligations. When the task cannot disappear and the framework tightens, people and relationships become buffers.

This appears as rework, repeated contact, private reminder lists, informal coordination, defensive professionalism, declining continuity, and documentation as armour. At the same time, the burden may be displaced onto citizens' time, relatives' unpaid work, civil society, nature, or future public budgets.

This is not primarily an efficiency problem.

It is a carrying-capacity problem.

Report 01 makes the problem concrete through a simple working movement:

1. Choose one bounded work field.
2. Read it through **Flow, Friction, and Sensitivity**.
3. Describe a small and honest initial state.
4. Make field temperature visible without making people transparent.
5. Test one reversible intervention.
6. Establish AI's mandate, human responsibility, stop, and repair.
7. Follow gains, displaced work, citizen burden, and the field's development.
8. Decide visibly where the released capacity should go.

The report's foundational figure is **municipal work as nature**. This does not mean that the municipality is literally an ecosystem. It means that work has living conditions: rhythm, nourishment, boundaries, relationships, variation, exhaustion, correction, and regeneration.

> Work is a field, not a queue.

> Capacity is not only time. It is judgement in a body. The living is not raw material for a system; it is the fixed point against which everything else must be measured.

> Economics is the infrastructure of thriving.

> Money is bound capacity. Therefore, *follow the money* also means *follow the body* and *follow the relationship*.

> Displaced work is not released work.

> No budget gain before field gain.

> No gain without an initial state. No effect narrative without net correction.

> AI can receive a mandate. It cannot receive responsibility for the mandate.

> Stopping, adjustment, and a negative result are legitimate outcomes.

Field Temperature

A work field can be operating in green, yellow, or red.

Green operations do not mean an absence of busyness or conflict. They mean that the task can be carried with professional judgement, relational continuity, capacity for correction, and regeneration intact.

Yellow operations mean that the field is still functioning, but increasingly through hidden compensation, rework, dependence on key individuals, or growing capacity debt.

Red operations are not a judgement of the employee. They are a signal that the system may no longer be able to carry the core task, rights, or the function of care without harm or persistent human overload.

> **Red is a demand that the system respond.**

Green, yellow, and red must not be used as HR, pay, absence, disciplinary, or performance data. The raw registration may constitute personal data. Field temperature must therefore be designed with short retention periods, minimum group sizes, aggregation, no individual histories, and an explicit prohibition on reuse for personnel assessment.

> **The person must be protected. The field must be legible. The system must be able to respond.**

AI as a Bounded Operational Actor

The Sophia Lumen way of working begins with human judgement, relationship, and responsibility. AI can support articulation, search, comparison, drafting, scenarios, and — under stronger conditions — reversible process steps.

Report 01 distinguishes between five levels of mandate:

1. reflection and analysis;
2. drafting and recommendation;
3. reversible execution under fixed criteria;
4. bounded process orchestration;
5. highly sensitive or irreversible decisions, in which legitimate authority and the final decisive impulse remain human and institutional.

The greater the mandate, the greater the risk of automation bias, responsibility fog, and a moral deformation zone in which the nearest employee is blamed for a system they do not genuinely control. Operational delegation must therefore never exceed the organisation's ability to understand, control, stop, and repair.

Aligned Intelligence is used here in a deliberately embodied and institutional sense. The fixed point is not the machine, its future trajectory, or an abstract intelligence. The fixed point is the living: the body, the nervous system, the relationship, the place, and the people who may be affected by a decision. AI must align itself with this primacy — not the other way round.

The order of priority is therefore:

1. dignity and fundamental rights;
2. the democratically decided core task;
3. the citizen's actual life and opportunity for correction;
4. professional judgement and responsibility;
5. the field's carrying capacity;
6. the public economy as a whole;
7. the long-term good of the commons;
8. operational efficiency;
9. possible budget savings.

The Phoenix Economy

The public economy must not be read as one large automatable cost base. Denmark's total public expenditure was provisionally DKK 1,472.8 billion in 2025. Social protection, health, education, and public services are to a large extent the very substance of the welfare state.

AI's relevant economic power lies in reducing unnecessary friction, connecting knowledge, detecting errors earlier, protecting human capacity, and preventing more costly breakdowns.

In 2024, Danish municipalities had approximately 418,300 full-time employees and a total payroll of DKK 220 billion. As pure scale scenarios, protecting or releasing:

- 0.10 per cent of capacity corresponds to approximately 418 full-time equivalents and a payroll equivalent of DKK 220 million;
- 0.25 per cent corresponds to approximately 1,046 full-time equivalents and DKK 550 million;
- 0.50 per cent corresponds to approximately 2,092 full-time equivalents and DKK 1.1 billion.

These are not forecasts or cash savings. Danish cases nevertheless show that substantial local gains can be documented: Ringkøbing-Skjern has calculated 37,400 released hours over three years; Vejle's screen-visit pilot calculated 68.1 hours per citizen annually and a total of approximately 2,800 hours, or 2.4 full-time equivalents, for about 40 citizens; and Copenhagen's user-management case shows why a large gross effect can become a much smaller net gain after development, operations, and continuing manual work.

The report distinguishes between:

- **G1 — released or protected capacity;**
- **G2 — documented avoided cost or harm;**
- **G3 — shared strategic and democratic capacity to act.**

The gain must be corrected for implementation, training, control, maintenance, error correction, new work, and burdens displaced onto others. Only then can the municipality decide:

1. what should repair capacity debt;
2. what should protect carrying capacity;
3. what can be shared with other pressured fields or with prevention;
4. and what may potentially become budgetary room for action.

Democratic Horizon

When field temperature, citizen experience, and economic effects can move through the system without making people transparent, the municipality can become better at sensing, learning, and correcting democratically.

In this movement, the citizen is not only a user, client, or source of data. *Knowing From the Ground* points towards the citizen as observer, bearer of knowledge, corrective, co-interpreter, and a gradually more sovereign democratic participant. Data should be offered, not extracted. AI can help people understand, formulate, and follow public processes, but must not become the superior interpreter of their experience.

> **The welfare state is not reborn by delivering more with ever less living capacity. It is reborn by releasing capacity from unnecessary friction and returning it to the core task, relationships, rights, and shared capacity to act.**

Report 01 does not offer a finished future welfare state. It shows how this force can begin to work under the right forms and in *right relationship* within one concrete municipal work field.

Part I — Where the State Meets Life

1. The Municipality as a Living Transition Zone

The municipality is the place where the promises of the welfare state become reality.

Not as an idea.

As an encounter.

As a relationship.

As a sentence.

As a decision.

As a home visit.

As a person who cannot go on.

As an employee who still turns up for work.

It is in the concrete transition between system and life that municipal work becomes most precise. A statutory provision, a budget, or a political decision is not complete when it has been adopted. It must be translated, interpreted, and carried in a concrete situation. It may meet a child, an older body, a family in crisis, a local community, a watercourse, a business, or a citizen who does not understand the digital message sent by the municipality.

The municipality therefore does not merely administer rules and services. It translates between worlds: between law and life, political prioritisation and local consequence, shared rights and different needs, standard and exception, technical model and lived place.

This translation is relational. A decision can be formally correct and still be delivered in a way that makes it almost impossible to understand. A service can have been delivered while the continuity that makes the help safe and professionally effective has disappeared. A plan can be legally valid and at the same time overlook the actual connections of the place. A digital solution can function technically while shifting large amounts of work onto the citizen or relatives.

The municipality is also a societal organ of sensing. It senses early when families lose their footing, when elder care fragments, when a system creates repeated problems, when a local community loses a shared place, when nature and infrastructure can no longer be treated separately, or when employees compensate for structural failure.

These signals rarely first appear as strategic key performance indicators. They appear as repeated enquiries, extra documentation, private lists, difficult conversations, moral strain, and the sentence: *It does not fit together*.

The municipality can sense only if the signals can move. If professional doubt is treated as inefficiency, the institution loses capacity for correction. If repeated citizen contact is treated only as demand, the possible learning about an unclear course of action is lost. If employees cannot describe hidden work without themselves being turned into the problem, the organisation becomes blind to its own foundation.

The Regenerative Municipality calls this capacity **precise democratic sensing**: concrete observations from citizens, employees, and places are connected with testing, responsibility, decision, feedback, and correction. Report 01 develops this sensing in the concrete work field; the companion report raises it into an intermunicipal architecture of reform, rights, and learning.

1.1 Cross-Pressure as an Operational State

Municipal operations work under simultaneous demands that cannot be reduced to a single cause: legislation and reform tracks; documentation and control; recruitment, absence, and staff turnover; fiscal frameworks and budget culture; complex citizen pathways; digital systems; climate, nature, and long-term resilience.

Cross-pressure is not in itself a sign of poor organisation. It is a fundamental condition. The problem arises when the organisation loses the ability to distinguish between the complexity genuinely inherent in the task and the friction produced by the design of work itself.

The task rarely disappears when the framework tightens. The child must still be met. The citizen must still receive a decision. The older person must still receive help. The road and sewer must still function. The water must still be managed. The cultural centre must still be able to hold a shared space. When formal capacity is reduced, the burden is displaced onto employees' extra work, citizens' waiting time, relatives' coordination, lower relational continuity, more defensive documentation, or deferred maintenance and nature expenditure.

It is therefore insufficient to ask only whether the organisation complies with budget and deadlines. A field can deliver many services while consuming its own future carrying capacity.

1.2 Green, Yellow, and Red Operations

Green, yellow, and red are field indicators, not HR categories.

In **green operations**, the field can carry its task. Responsibility is sufficiently clear. Professional judgement can be exercised. Errors are discovered and corrected. Documentation has a comprehensible function. Load is followed by an opportunity for regulation and recovery. Green operations do not mean an absence of conflict or busyness; they mean functioning with capacity for correction and regeneration intact.

In **yellow operations**, the field functions increasingly through compensation. Rework grows. Informal solutions become permanent. Dependence on particular key people increases. Handover becomes weaker. Documentation becomes more defensive. There is still life in the field, but its resilience is declining.

In **red operations**, formal functioning is maintained through persistent overload, loss, or risk. People become permanent buffers. Errors cannot be properly investigated. Stop options exist only on paper. The citizen, a relative, or a single employee becomes the actual coordinator. Documentation protects the system more than the right. A red state can still produce green numbers on selected indicators. This is precisely why averages and productivity figures must never stand alone.

1.3 Field Temperature — Protecting the Person, Making the Field Legible

Field temperature is a collective assessment of the conditions of the work field. It is not a diagnosis of the individual employee and not an indirect measure of mood, loyalty, resilience, or productivity.

An employee provides a situated signal: *Can this field currently carry the task responsibly?* The signal may concern time, professional discretion, relational continuity, transfer of responsibility, the possibility of correcting errors, capacity debt, or risk of harm.

The legal and organisational boundary must be formulated precisely. A raw response may constitute personal data if it can be connected to the employee who provided it. Pseudonymisation is not the same as anonymisation. It is therefore insufficient simply to declare that the colours “are not HR data”.

The correct design requirement is:

> **The purpose of field temperature is not to assess the individual employee, and the system must be designed technically, organisationally, and legally so that individual signals cannot be reused as HR, control, absence, or performance data.**

A responsible practice requires, among other things:

- no management access to individual responses;
- no permanent individual temperature histories;
- no linkage with appraisal interviews, pay, absence, productivity, or personnel cases;
- no mandatory free text that can identify people;
- minimum group sizes and suppression of small groups;
- short retention of raw signals;
- aggregated patterns rather than individual profiles;
- shared governance with the working-environment organisation and employee representation;
- clear information about purpose, access, retention, and use;
- the right not to respond when a response cannot be given truthfully or safely.

Field temperature must not be inferred through emotion recognition, biometric analysis, tone of voice, keystrokes, facial expression, sentiment analysis of emails, or hidden behavioural profiling. It must be a consciously provided assessment of working conditions — not machine reading of a person’s inner life.

The individual signal becomes organisational knowledge only through aggregation, interpretation, and feedback. A colour without shared inquiry can easily become just another management figure. A field must therefore be able to describe:

- what makes it green, yellow, or red;
- which conditions lie within local capacity to act;
- which conditions cut across departments;
- which conditions follow from political priorities, legislation, or financing;
- what action the signal triggers;

- and what happened afterwards.

An organisation in which employees risk sanction or suspicion for reporting red does not have field temperature. It has a green-reporting mechanism.

> **Management must reward truthful sensing, not comfortable signals.**

1.4 From the Field’s Signal to Democratic Responsibility

Field temperature changes the responsibility of management.

Management is not about returning the indicator to green. Management is about investigating what the signal says about the core task and taking responsibility for the conditions that lie within the organisation’s power.

A red pattern may indicate a need for more resources. But it may also reveal:

- conflicting rules;
- a broken workflow;
- weak coordination;
- an unsuitable digital system;
- an unclear mandate;
- discontinued maintenance;
- a task that no longer creates public value;
- or a central-government reform whose actual implementation burden has been underestimated.

Red should therefore trigger a fixed but proportionate process:

1. The field describes the load without identifying individual employees.
2. Management investigates whether the cause is local, cross-cutting, political, or external.
3. Economics, law, professional practice, citizen experience, and the working environment are read together.
4. A relief measure, correction, or reversible intervention is selected.
5. Responsibility, timeframe, and feedback are made visible.
6. The temperature is followed after the intervention.
7. If the cause lies in central-government regulation or financing, the signal is passed onwards.

The municipal council should not see individual responses. It should be able to see institutional patterns: which core tasks are under persistent pressure, which priorities create conflicting demands, where savings merely displace burden, and where the organisation uses people as a buffer between statutory expectations and inadequate conditions.

Field temperature is therefore more than management information.

It is **democratic institutional sensing**.

2. Work as Nature

Describing municipal work as nature is not metaphorical decoration. Nor is it a claim that a municipality is literally a biological ecosystem.

It is a working proposition:

> Work has living conditions.

People and relationships have rhythms. Attention can be nourished and exhausted. A field can absorb variation, but not indefinitely. Load requires regulation. Boundaries can protect integrity or sever necessary connections. Diversity of knowledge can increase resilience. Ruptures require repair. Capacity cannot be extracted permanently without consequence.

2.1 Rhythm

All municipal work fields have rhythms: days, weeks, school years, budget years, holiday periods, seasons, political cycles, acute events, and longer pathways. Home care does not have the same rhythm as a planning department. A child's development does not follow the authority's case calendar. A local community can take years to build and disappear within a few months.

When work is organised as though load were constant, a permanent state of exception can easily arise. Rhythm may therefore require protected overlaps, coherent professional time, periods for preparation, seasonally adjusted capacity, and the possibility of digesting difficult conversations or intensive periods.

Rhythm is not a soft addition to operations. It is an operational condition.

2.2 Load and Regulation

Load is not in itself harmful. A living system can handle intensity if it has a clear function, beginning, and end, and if the field can return to a sustainable state.

Many small, unfinished loads can be more erosive than one intense period: constant interruptions; unclear transfers of responsibility; repeated errors; systems requiring permanent manual compensation; moral conflicts without a legitimate route; tasks that never feel complete.

Regulation is therefore more than a break. It is the field's possibility of re-establishing coherence, attention, and capacity to act after load.

2.3 Nourishment

A work field is nourished by what makes good task performance possible: professional trust, a clear mandate, usable tools, collegial continuity, comprehensible decisions, the possibility of learning from errors, access to relevant knowledge, time for an important conversation, and management capable of receiving bad news.

Nourishment is not the same as comfort. A field can be full of conflict and still be nourishing if conflicts can be spoken openly and lead to understanding or correction. An apparently harmonious field can be depleted if problems have become unsayable.

2.4 Boundaries and Diversity

The municipality consists of boundaries between authority and provider, professions, departments, the state, region, municipality, private suppliers, digital systems, and the citizen's life. Some boundaries protect rights, confidentiality, or responsibility. Others create loss because relevant knowledge and responsibility cannot pass through.

A healthy boundary is permeable to what must move and protective of what must not be extracted.

Municipal practice requires legal knowledge, professional experience, the citizen's own experience, technical understanding, economic overview, relational sensing, and knowledge of place. None of these alone can carry complex work fields. A field becomes fragile when one form of knowledge gains a monopoly on defining reality.

2.5 Regeneration

Regeneration does not mean that everything must grow. It means that the field can rebuild the capacity it uses.

This may require removing a registration requirement, abolishing a meeting, rolling back an automation, ending a temporary solution, or sharing a responsibility. A field does not necessarily regenerate by receiving yet another project. It may regenerate by being allowed to stop compensating for something that no longer serves the task.

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3. The Human Being and the Relationship as Buffer

When the carrying capacity of the work field is reduced, the burden does not disappear. It moves.

An employee remembers what the system cannot remember. A manager connects what the organisation has separated. A citizen calls again because the letter did not create understanding. A relative coordinates between public functions. A professional spends extra time ensuring that a standard procedure does not harm the concrete situation.

This compensation is often professionally and humanly valuable. The problem arises when it becomes permanent, invisible, and private. The organisation may then appear stable because people informally carry its lack of coherence.

The hidden capacity consists of time, memory, care, conscience, improvisation, translation, informal coordination, and relational repair. It is not free. It is borrowed from the person's attention, body, relationships, and future carrying capacity.

3.1 The Work of Translation

Municipal work takes place between different languages: those of law, economics, professional practice, technology, politics, and the citizen's concrete experience. The employee translates a rule into an action, a system output into a comprehensible answer, a citizen's story into an administrative category, and professional doubt into something to which the organisation can respond.

The translation is not mechanical. It requires understanding both the system and the life in which the system must work. When time is reduced or standardisation becomes too tight, the words may arrive while the meaning is lost.

3.2 The Citizen, Relatives, and Civil Society as Buffer

The citizen becomes a buffer when they must find the responsible person, repeat information, understand contradictory messages, discover errors, or coordinate between systems. Friction hits particularly hard when the person is simultaneously ill, under financial pressure, in crisis, or without strong linguistic, digital, or social resources.

Relatives and civil society carry significant parts of the social infrastructure. They help with translation, continuity, observation, participation, and relational repair. But community must not be reduced to free reserve capacity. When the municipal task functions only because others take over coordination and care without sufficient support or influence, responsibility has been displaced in a hidden way.

3.3 Rotation Before Heroes

Many work fields are carried by key people who know whom to contact, how the systems actually work, and how a difficult case or local relationship can be moved forward. Their contribution should be recognised. But an organisation that functions only through heroes is not robust.

Rotation does not mean that everyone is interchangeable. It means that no one should be forced permanently to carry the organisation's missing connections. Knowledge and responsibility must be able to move through overlap, partnership, shared reflection, and gradual handover. Relational continuity should be preserved, while structural dependence on one person should be reduced.

> Rotation before heroes is both care and governance.

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4. Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity is the report's shared grammar of reading. The triad is not a score, an algorithm, or a universal management model. It is an apparatus for listening.

4.1 Flow

Flow is the necessary movement through the work field: information, understanding, responsibility, professional assessment, consent, physical assistance, financial support, relational continuity, or knowledge of the next step.

Flow is not the same as speed. A slow pathway can have good flow if time is used for necessary observation, consultation, or professional investigation. A fast pathway can have poor flow if meaning, context, or responsibility is lost.

Not everything should flow. Confidential information must be protected. A child's story should not circulate merely because more people are interested. An employee's personal reflection should not automatically become shared data. Good flow makes the necessary mobile and keeps the sensitive protected.

4.2 Friction

Friction is not every form of resistance. Consultation of a party, professional disagreement, safety control, and time for relationship can protect something legitimate.

Friction is the work, waiting time, or resistance that binds capacity without protecting a right, quality, or safety and without moving the task correspondingly forward. It may be repetition with no new function, waiting without responsibility, rework after known errors, handovers without preserved context, documentation nobody uses, or systems requiring permanent manual repair.

Friction is also a trace. A private list may reveal that the shared system does not carry the necessary memory. An overloaded key person may reveal that the connections have become person-borne. A growing document may reveal that responsibility and risk are unclear.

4.3 Sensitivity

Sensitivity concerns how much can be lost, who bears the loss, how easily it is detected, and how difficult it is to repair.

A factual error may perhaps be corrected quickly. An error affecting a child's trust, a citizen's housing, an older person's medication, or an irreversible condition in nature can have much greater and longer consequences.

An average gain is insufficient if a smaller group is exposed to severe harm. Sensitivity makes the distribution visible.

4.4 The Triad in Practice

A work field can begin with six questions:

1. What must be able to move for the task to succeed?
2. What meaning must not be lost?
3. Where are time, attention, or relational capacity bound?

4. What legitimate function does the resistance serve?
5. What can be lost, and who bears the consequence?
6. Where must a human opportunity to stop and correct be possible?

The triad does not close the inquiry. It opens it.

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5. Morality, Decency, and Documentation as Armour

Municipal work is moral work because municipal actions affect people's possibilities of understanding, participating, preserving dignity, and trusting shared institutions.

Morality is not only a question of values or intention. It is also a question of capacity. A person may know what is right and still lack the time, mandate, information, or organisational safety to do it.

Institutions shape moral possibility through rhythms, forms of measurement, responsibility, information flows, documentation requirements, management responses, and access to stopping and correction.

5.1 Moral Strain

Moral strain arises when an employee repeatedly experiences a gap between what is judged professionally or humanly right and what is actually possible. It may mean ending a conversation too early, sending a letter expected to create uncertainty, watching a pathway fragment without a mandate to bring it together, or correcting the same systematic error case by case.

Moral strain can lead to distance, mechanical language, silence, cynicism, or excessive personal assumption of responsibility. Both extremes are signs of a field that no longer distributes responsibility and load responsibly.

5.2 Decency as an Operational State

Decency is operational. It consists in providing a comprehensible reason, avoiding unnecessary humiliation, stating who is responsible, protecting confidential matters, saying what the municipality does not yet know, and making correction possible.

The municipality can say no and still act decently. It can impose requirements and still protect dignity. Decency is not the opposite of authority, but a quality of legitimate exercise of public authority.

5.3 Documentation as Protection

Documentation can protect rights, professional assessments, continuity, reviewability, and organisational memory. It has a living function when it helps the field remember, understand, coordinate, justify, correct, and learn.

The report distinguishes between necessary documentation, rights-protecting documentation, learning documentation, and defensive production of control.

5.4 Documentation as Armour

Documentation becomes armour when text and registration primarily absorb organisational uncertainty or displace responsibility. The same information is registered in several places. Standard texts grow to cover every conceivable situation. More approvals are introduced because no one has a mandate to decide. The concrete assessment disappears in the volume of text.

> The paradox of armour is that more documentation can make responsibility less visible.

The citizen must see through a larger mass of text. The employee must produce and check more. The organisation may still lack the precise documentation that would actually protect the right or enable learning.

When generative AI makes text cheaper to produce, this risk grows. A rapid draft is not a gain if it creates longer documents, more versions, and a greater need for control.

The companion report *The Regenerative Municipality* gathers the digital and administrative control test in **the Orwell Test**:

> Does the solution create control without corresponding insight, counter-power, and the possibility of repair?

The test does not replace the concrete legal, professional, or democratic assessment. It makes visible at an early stage when more registration, automation, or documentation increases institutional control without increasing the affected person's understanding, capacity to act, or access to correction.

Three stop questions remain relevant:

> Does this become more text or more clarity?

> Are we moving responsibility away from an identifiable person?

> Are we making the field more repairable or more armoured?

Part II — The Phoenix Economy: Capacity, Burden, and Total Public Value

6. Economics as the Infrastructure of Thriving

This chapter translates *work as nature* into municipal economics.

Not only as a spreadsheet.

As a grammar.

Economics determines pace, staffing, maintenance, robustness, and the possibility of responding before a load becomes a breakdown. It therefore also shapes whether the work field can be green, yellow, or red.

6.1 Service, Capital, and Transfers

The municipality's economic categories have different relationships to the work field.

Service and operations contain a large share of human and relational capacity: employee time, teaching, care, exercise of public authority, administration, culture, and daily maintenance. When the service-expenditure ceiling tightens without the task correspondingly disappearing, people easily become the buffer.

Capital expenditure creates buildings, roads, systems, and physical infrastructure. Capital investment can strengthen future operations, but it can also impose persistent costs or friction on operations. A solution that is inexpensive to build may be costly in maintenance, control, or relational repair work.

Transfers are not ordinary municipal production. They affect people's material ability to live, eat, travel, and participate. An administrative delay can therefore rapidly become social and health-related escalation.

The categories must not be mixed when gains are calculated. Released employee time in service provision is not automatically a cash saving. A capital investment is not an operational gain until its total effect is understood. A change in transfers cannot be assessed solely as municipal administrative economics.

6.2 The Service-Expenditure Ceiling as a Field Boundary

The service-expenditure ceiling functions as a real boundary on how much municipal operation can be financed. It may be necessary as a form of macroeconomic governance, but its effects become concrete locally.

When the task, statutory requirements, and citizen needs remain while the framework tightens, efficiency does not arise automatically. Intensification, hidden overtime, lower relational quality, more standardisation, and fewer opportunities for prevention and correction may arise instead.

The economic question is therefore not only whether expenditure has remained within the ceiling. It is also what the ceiling makes the field do with people's time, professional practice, and relationships.

6.3 Demographics, Equalisation, Reimbursement, and Liquidity

Municipalities' room for action is affected by population composition, social and geographical structure, the equalisation system, reimbursement rules, and liquidity. In the municipal introduction landscapes, these mechanisms are addressed through dated official sources; their concrete effect must always be assessed in the local economic and organisational context.

Demographics change the composition and rhythm of tasks. Equalisation and reimbursement affect where costs and incentives are placed. Liquidity affects the municipality's ability to invest before breakdown and carry transition costs. A municipality may have a long-term opportunity for gain while lacking the short-term financial capacity to realise it.

A technical business case is therefore never the entire basis for a decision.

6.4 Economics as Public Prioritisation

Economics is not only a constraint. It is also a language of prioritisation. A budget determines whether there is overlap between shifts, time for professional reflection, continuity around children and older people, maintenance before breakdown, early local involvement, or the possibility of repairing an error.

Scarcer resources do not make work ecology less relevant. They make it more important to distinguish between necessary public capacity and friction that merely binds resources.

6.5 The Scale of the Public Economy

Denmark's total public expenditure was provisionally DKK 1,472.8 billion in 2025. The distribution by purpose shows that social protection accounted for 41 per cent, health for 17 per cent, education for 12 per cent, and general public services for 12 per cent.

Converted into approximate amounts:

Public purpose	Share in 2025	Approximate expenditure
Social protection	41 per cent	DKK 604 billion
Health	17 per cent	DKK 250 billion
Education	12 per cent	DKK 177 billion
General public services	12 per cent	DKK 177 billion
Economic affairs	6 per cent	DKK 88 billion
Defence	5 per cent	DKK 74 billion
Public order and safety	2 per cent	DKK 29 billion

Source: Statistics Denmark, *General Government Accounts 2022–2025*, published 3 June 2026. The amounts are the report's rounded calculations based on the published shares.

The figures must not be used to portray the entire public sector as one large automatable cost. A large share of the amount is the very substance of the welfare state: income security, care, treatment, teaching, rights, defence, emergency preparedness, and infrastructure.

The relevant question is therefore not:

> What percentage of DKK 1,472.8 billion can AI save?

The relevant question is:

> Where in the total economy is capacity bound in unnecessary friction, where is expensive repair of earlier failure produced, and where can released capacity be returned to direct welfare and democratic/regenerative capacity to act?

Even small shares illustrate the scale of the system. Mathematically, 0.1 per cent of total public expenditure corresponds to approximately DKK 1.47 billion; 0.5 per cent to DKK 7.36 billion; and 1 per cent to DKK 14.73 billion. These amounts are not measures of effect or savings forecasts. They show only why small systemic changes can become significant — and why documentation discipline must be strict.

6.6 Five Flows in the Public Budget

Official public accounts are divided by authority, function, and account. The Phoenix account adds a cross-cutting reading of what the expenditure does.

A. Direct welfare

Care, income security, teaching, treatment, protection, mobility, access, and rights. This flow must not be made efficient out of existence.

B. Necessary institutional infrastructure

Professional documentation, legal safeguards, supervision, democratic decision-making, data security, redundancy, maintenance, and control of power. It can be improved, but not simply removed.

C. Unnecessary friction

Double registration, manual transfers, repeated enquiries, incompatible systems, unclear responsibilities, defensive documentation, and waiting time without public value.

D. The repair economy

Reprocessing, complaints, acute interventions, temporary staffing, legal proceedings, breakdown, escalation of conflict, and rebuilding lost relationship or trust.

E. Regenerative and democratic capacity

Prevention, local observation, shared learning, citizen participation, open methods, public technological sovereignty, care for places and commons, and the institution's ability to correct itself.

In economic terms, the Phoenix movement consists in shifting resources from unnecessary friction and avoidable repair towards direct welfare and regenerative/democratic capacity — without hollowing out necessary institutional infrastructure.

6.7 The Municipal Labour Market as Living Capacity

In 2024, Danish municipalities had approximately 528,200 employees, corresponding to 418,300 full-time employees, and a total payroll of DKK 220 billion. The average payroll equivalent is therefore approximately DKK 526,000 per full-time equivalent. The figure is an anchor of scale, not a complete marginal cost.

Protected or released capacity	Full-time equivalents	Payroll equivalent
0.10 per cent	approx. 418	approx. DKK 220 million
0.25 per cent	approx. 1,046	approx. DKK 550 million
0.50 per cent	approx. 2,092	approx. DKK 1.1 billion
1.00 per cent	approx. 4,183	approx. DKK 2.2 billion

Source: Local Government Denmark (KL), *The Municipal Labour Market in Figures 2024*. The scenarios are calculations made by this report and must not be read as expected AI effects.

The 2026 agreement on municipal finances sets a service-expenditure ceiling of DKK 336.8 billion, total municipal expenditure of DKK 501.8 billion in the agreement's balance, and an administrative reduction of DKK 250 million. The lower end of the February report's illustrative scenario — an average capacity equivalent of five full-time equivalents across 98 municipalities — corresponds to approximately 490 full-time equivalents and a payroll equivalent of around DKK 258 million.

The similarity in order of magnitude is not evidence that technology can or should deliver the administrative reduction in the financial agreement. It shows the difference between two logics:

- An external budget requirement determines the reduction first.
- The Phoenix account first documents whether net capacity actually exists, who produced it, what the field needs, and which part can be allocated without harm.

6.8 Sickness Absence as a Sign of Capacity Debt — Not as an Automatic Source of Savings

Average municipal sickness absence was 13.9 working days per full-time employee in 2024. In elder care, health, and disability services, it was 16.3 working days; in administration, 9.1.

Across 418,300 full-time employees, 13.9 days correspond mathematically to approximately 5.8 million days of absence. A change of one average day would correspond to approximately 418,000 working days or around 1,900 full-time equivalents of capacity at 220 working days.

This is not a savings potential, and the report claims no causal relationship between AI, field temperature, and national sickness absence. Employees continue to receive pay, causes are many, and part of any possible effect would appear as continuity, lower pressure from temporary staffing and overtime, and reduced load on colleagues.

The figures instead show the magnitude of the capacity dimension that the condition of the work field may have, and why field temperature is of interest as a possible early indicator before capacity debt becomes visible in absence, turnover, errors, and breakdown.

7. Follow the Money, Body, and Relationship

When the report says *follow the money*, it does not mean only locating the budget line.

It means following capacity.

Where does time disappear? Where does rework become normal? Who performs the informal control? Who coordinates? Where does waiting time become further harm? Which relationship holds a formal system together?

> Money is bound capacity. Capacity is judgement in a body. Therefore, *follow the money* also means *follow the body* and *follow the relationship*.

7.1 Friction as a Hidden Budget Item

Friction becomes economics when it binds hours, creates reprocessing, produces meeting inflation, increases absence, leads to complaints or escalation, and makes the organisation dependent on costly acute repair.

It may be visible in:

- repeated citizen contacts;
- reopened cases;
- document versions;
- waiting time between functions;
- overtime and absence;
- staff turnover;
- complaints and remittals;
- parallel lists and systems;
- time spent by relatives and citizens;
- deferred maintenance;
- conflicts arising because participation came too late.

Friction must not be confused with all time-consuming work. Time for relationship, consultation, protection of rights, professional disagreement, maintenance, and observation can be productive public capacity. The question is what function the time serves.

Friction is not always unintended. The report distinguishes between:

- **protective friction**, which safeguards rights, professional thoroughness, and democratic counter-power;
- **unintended friction**, arising through system breaks, repetition, and unclear responsibility;
- **distributive friction**, which deliberately or in practice restricts access or moves work and risk onto particular people.

The final form cannot be treated solely as a process problem. It requires political visibility: Who decided that the burden should exist, what purpose does it serve, and who bears its price?

7.2 The Per-Citizen Layer and Scale

Per-citizen figures can make municipalities comparable, but they can also conceal differences in demographics, geography, task profile, social structure, and organisational design.

The per-citizen layer should therefore be used for orientation, not as a ranking. It must be accompanied by a description of what the amount contains, which tasks are particularly demanding, and which costs lie outside the municipality's own accounts.

Scale matters. Five minutes of unnecessary work in a rare pathway is not the same as five minutes in a high-volume field. But scale alone cannot determine priority; a rare error may be more sensitive and irreversible.

7.3 The Follow-the-Money Card

A light-touch card can contain:

Layer	Question
Formal budget	Where is the expenditure located: service, capital, transfer, or another category?
Work process	Which people, systems, and handovers carry the task?
Hidden capacity	What additional work is performed without being visible in the process?
Citizen and relationship	What time and burden are moved outside the organisation?
Friction	Where do repetition, waiting, control, and rework arise?
Sensitivity	What can be lost, and how reversible is it?
Time	What is transition cost, operation, and long-term consequence?
Gain	Is the effect G1, G2, or G3, and who receives it?

The card should be capable of completion using existing knowledge and a small number of supplementary observations. If the mapping requires a new and extensive registration machine, it contradicts its own purpose.

7.4 Six Simultaneous Accounts

A work field cannot be assessed through a single economic number. The Phoenix account holds six accounts side by side.

Account	Question
Operations and capacity	What rework, search time, and coordination friction have actually been reduced after all new costs?
Budget economy	Which expenditures or revenues actually change, for which budget holder, and over what period?
Field balance	Has the work field become greener, or is the gain produced through new intensification and capacity debt?
Citizen and surrounding world	Have work, time, risk, or expenditure been shifted onto citizens, relatives, civil society, businesses, or nature?

Account	Question
Welfare and rights	Have quality, comprehensibility, continuity, access, and the possibility of correction improved or deteriorated?
Commons and democracy	Have shared learning, public control, technological sovereignty, and the possibility of democratic correction been strengthened?

The accounts must not be compressed into one monetary total. Some entries are kroner, others hours, events, distributive effects, or non-compensatory rights requirements.

A positive budget entry cannot compensate for systematic deterioration of fundamental rights or for a work field being operated persistently in red.

8. Baseline, Intervention, Net Correction, and G1/G2/G3

A change cannot be called a gain merely because it feels promising or creates a technical improvement.

The report's **G1/G2/G3 gain discipline** is:

> No gain without an initial state. No effect narrative without net correction.

8.1 A Living Initial State

A baseline is a sufficient description of the work field before the intervention. It may include numbers of repeated contacts, waiting time, handovers, document versions, control time, errors, and citizen understanding. But it must also examine how the task is performed: hidden overtime, dependence on key people, relational continuity, and the possibility of correction.

A small, honest baseline is better than a large, falsely precise measurement.

8.2 The Intervention as a Hypothesis

An intervention must be formulated as a hypothesis:

> If we change X in this bounded work field, we expect Y to improve without Z deteriorating.

Z is decisive. A faster process is not a gain if legal safeguards, comprehensibility, relational quality, or nature's long-term carrying capacity are weakened.

The intervention must have an identifiable responsibility-holder, a clear scope, stop criteria, and a practical alternative or previous work path.

Gold Before Bloom — a Condition of Entry

Gold Before Bloom is not a promise that everything must first be perfect. It is a discipline of sequence: before a new system, a new measurement, or a new innovation obligation is placed on top of the field, known red operations, unclear responsibility, and existing needs for repair must have been made visible and manageable.

A field must not receive greater technological complexity than it has the human and organisational capacity to understand, correct, and maintain. If basic safety, responsibility, data quality, or the possibility of stopping are missing, the intervention must first create these conditions or be postponed.

Otherwise, innovation risks making a burdened field more advanced without making it more sustainable.

8.3 Net Correction

Net correction asks:

- What improved?
- What deteriorated?
- What did not change?
- What capacity did the intervention require?
- Where did the work or risk move?
- Who received the gain, and who bore the cost?
- Which simultaneous conditions affected the result?
- What can the material not tell us?

A digital solution can reduce internal processing time and create more work for citizens. A shorter text may require more oral explanation. An optimised route may weaken continuity. Net correction follows the entire relevant field.

8.4 G1 — Released or Protected Capacity

G1 is less rework, fewer repetitions, better handovers, more coherent professional time, better relational continuity, or less dependence on hidden compensation.

Released time is not automatically a budget saving. It may be used for existing backlogs, quality, prevention, relationship, training, or recovery.

8.5 G2 — Avoided Cost or Harm

G2 may consist of fewer errors, complaints, escalations, reopened pathways, breakdowns, acute interventions, or irreversible losses in nature and place.

It must be clear whether the gain is observed, rendered plausible, calculated, or solely a design hypothesis. A hypothetical future harm must not be presented as a realised saving.

8.6 G3 — Strategic Room for Action and Robustness

G3 arises when the municipality gains a genuine possibility of choosing differently: investing in prevention, maintenance, relational continuity, professional depth, local commons, or ecological capacity.

G3 does not exist merely because a spreadsheet shows a possibility. A legitimate decision-maker must actually be able to reallocate the capacity.

8.7 Regenerative Reinvestment — the Gain Must Have a Route Back

A municipality is not a nervous system. Municipal administrations do, however, perform nervous-system functions.

They register changes in people, places, and tasks. They carry signals forward, connect experience with law, economics, and professional practice, prioritise, act, discover effects, correct, and learn. A healthy work field must not only be able to react quickly. It must also be able to inhibit, distinguish, recover, and repair.

AI can support this capacity. It can reduce repetition, make information easier to find, support formulation, and release time from particular workflows. But faster signal processing is not the same as better regulation.

If all released capacity is immediately converted into more tasks, higher production requirements, or a general budget reduction, AI can make a yellow or red field work faster without making it greener. The gain may be real while its use is extractive.

The following rule therefore applies:

> **No budget gain before field gain.**

Before an AI or process gain is treated as economic room for action, the municipality must be able to show:

1. that the gain remains after implementation, training, control, error correction, and new or displaced work;
2. that quality, relationship, legal safeguards, professional judgement, and the possibility of correction have not deteriorated;
3. that the field is sufficiently stable for the capacity actually to be allocated;
4. that the use of the gain has been decided visibly and legitimately.

The regenerative order is:

1. Repair the Capacity Debt

First, examine whether the field carries backlog, exhaustion, lost professional learning, insufficient relational continuity, weak maintenance, or inadequate capacity for correction. Part of the gain may be necessary simply to make operations responsible again.

2. Protect the New Carrying Capacity

Next, invest in what makes the gain durable: professional time, relationship, training, overlap, control, maintenance, human alternatives, and the possibility of learning from errors.

3. Share the Municipal Gain

Once the field is stable, an actual gain can be shared with other burdened fields, prevention, shared infrastructure, political room for action, or genuine budget relief.

The point is not that every hour or krone must forever remain bound to the organisational unit in which the gain arose. The municipality is a shared political and economic system. The point is that the gain must not disappear before someone has considered what the field needs in order to continue sensing, assessing, acting, correcting, and repairing.

> **If the gain is detached from the field that created it and disappears into an opaque budget hole before the field has regained its carrying capacity, the regenerative loop is broken.**

Regenerative economic care does not consist in rejecting savings. It consists in making the origin, net effect, distribution, and use of the saving visible.

Reinvestment in relationship, professional time, or stabilisation is not a deduction from success. In a burdened work field, it may be the success itself.

8.8 No Double Counting and Non-Compensatory Conditions

The same effect must not be registered as both released time, avoided payroll expenditure, and new budgetary room for action without separate documentation.

Nor may certain conditions be compensated away in one combined calculation. A time gain cannot automatically outweigh weakened legal safeguards, lack of human control, hidden profiling, loss of confidentiality, or irreversible loss in nature.

An intervention can be green on one indicator and red on another. The red state must not be dissolved in the average.

8.9 A Shared 90-Day Pilot Format

Where a fixed pilot period is useful, Report 01 uses the same **90-day rhythm** as its companion report *The Regenerative Municipality*. Report 01 retains its operational step logic but gathers it into four decision gates:

Decision gate	Work
Days 1–15	Mandate, delimitation, identifiable responsibility, and minimum baseline
Days 16–30	Precise baseline, work-field map, rights, protected conditions, and stop criteria
Days 31–75	One reversible intervention with short correction loops, at least weekly

Decision gate	Work
Days 76–90	Post-measurement, net correction, G1/G2/G3 reading, and decision on continuation, adjustment, further inquiry, or stopping

Some work fields require shorter or longer observation. Any deviation must then be justified by the rhythm and sensitivity of the task. The 90 days are a shared municipal pilot format, not a requirement that biological, relational, or physical effects must be fully visible by day 90.

8.10 Monday Start — the Smallest Thing That Can Be Done Without Lying

A municipality does not need to wait for a large project in order to begin. A legitimate first step can be undertaken as a short, shared field reading:

1. **Choose one type of task.** Delimit the beginning, the end, and the desired living outcome.
2. **Read Flow · Friction · Sensitivity for 30 minutes.** What must move, where is capacity bound, and what may be significantly lost?
3. **Choose a few baseline proxies from existing data.** For example, repeated contacts, handovers, reprocessing, waiting time, or a simple green/yellow/red field assessment.
4. **Formulate one reversible intervention.** State what is expected to improve and what must not deteriorate.
5. **Agree the stop, responsibility, and next decision.** Who can respond, where is the alternative route, and when will the pathway be assessed again?

The Monday start is not a miniature implementation. It is a test of whether the field can become legible without creating a new burden of measurement or meetings. It may conclude that the municipality is not ready for a pilot because red operations, an unclear mandate, or inadequate correction capacity must first be addressed. That is also a legitimate outcome.

8.11 Six Recurring Worked Examples

The worked examples show the full movement from baseline to net correction, field test, and reinvestment decision.

Figures marked **illustrative scenario** are assumptions made by this report. Figures marked **empirical anchor** come from a published source. No case may be transferred directly to another municipality or workflow.

Example A — High Volume and Repeated Contact

Illustrative scenario

An administrative field handles 6,000 pathways a year. The baseline shows an average of 10 minutes of avoidable rework or repeated contact per pathway.

> 6,000 pathways × 10 minutes = 60,000 minutes = 1,000 hours of annual friction.

A change to the first response, status display, and transfer of responsibility is tested.

Scenario	Reduction in observed friction	Gross release
Cautious	20 per cent	200 hours
Central	40 per cent	400 hours
Strong	60 per cent	600 hours

First-year design, employee involvement, training, control, error correction, and handling of new exceptions are calculated at 200 hours.

Scenario	Gross	New costs	Possible net G1
Cautious	200	200	0 hours
Central	400	200	200 hours
Strong	600	200	400 hours

The strong scenario does not automatically yield 400 hours of budget savings. A legitimate distribution could, for example, be:

- 150 hours for backlog and stabilisation;
- 120 hours for better citizen contact;
- 80 hours for training, sampling, and correction capacity;
- 50 hours as potentially allocable capacity.

Only the final share can be considered as budgetary room for action, and only if the time can actually be gathered and realised without new harm.

Example B — Relational Continuity in Elder Care & Health

Empirical anchor

KL's case analysis describes how the Municipality of Vejle calculated 68.1 effective released working hours per citizen annually from screen visits in two home-care districts. For approximately 40 citizens, this corresponded to around 2,800 hours or 2.4 full-time equivalents. KL calculated the annual gain at approximately DKK 1 million and the expected net gain in 2022 at approximately DKK 1.3 million. The case also reported high satisfaction among citizens and employees.

The case shows real potential, but Report 01's net correction asks further questions:

- Which citizens are suited to screen visits, and which are not?
- Is there free and practical access to a physical visit?
- Who provides technical assistance?
- Is work shifted onto the citizen or relatives?
- How is the ability to register changes in body, home, and relationship affected?
- Does travel time become more presence, more stable planning, or a budget reduction?

Illustrative Phoenix distribution of 2,800 net hours

Use	Hours
Protected physical time for highly sensitive citizens	1,100
Overlap, continuity, and follow-up	700
Technical assistance, training, and quality control	400
Capacity for other pressured districts	400
Possible budgetary room for action	200
Total	**2,800**

The distribution is not the Municipality of Vejle's actual decision. It demonstrates the report's principle: reinvestment in relational quality is not a deduction from success. It may be the primary public effect.

Example C — Highly Sensitive Exercise of Public Authority

Empirical context

In 2024, the Danish Appeals Board reversed or remitted 31 per cent of the municipal complaint cases it decided on the merits. The reversal rate is not an error rate for all municipal decisions; it concerns the selected subset that was appealed and decided on the merits.

Illustrative local baseline

An authority field reviews 200 highly sensitive cases and records:

- 46 repeat enquiries caused by an unclear next step;
- 28 factual corrections after dispatch;
- 18 internal transfers of responsibility without a clear responsibility-holder;
- 12 formal complaints;
- a total of 420 hours of rework and correction work.

An AI-assisted but humanly responsibility-bearing practice is tested for fact-checking, plain language, a visible responsibility-holder, and a mandatory counter-question before dispatch.

After the period, the following are observed:

- 220 fewer hours of rework;
- 90 hours of implementation, professional control, and verification;
- a possible net G1 of 130 hours;
- fewer unclear transitions;
- one possibly avoided serious escalation.

The 130 hours can be documented. The avoided escalation cannot automatically be entered in the accounts as certain G2. It is registered as a possible secondary effect until the connection, alternative pathway, and budget consequence can be rendered plausible.

In a highly sensitive field, a small G1 may be accompanied by great public value through better rights, earlier correction, and lower risk of serious harm.

Example D — Cross-Cutting Coordination and Cost Displacement

Illustrative scenario using SØM logic

An early, coordinated intervention for 100 citizens costs one municipal unit DKK 2.0 million over two years.

The expected and subsequently observed movement is:

Budget or life domain	Cost / possible consequence
Municipal intervention	−DKK 2.0 million
Less acute municipal support	+DKK 0.8 million
Less regional activity	+DKK 0.7 million
Lower state transfer / greater employment	+DKK 0.6 million
Citizen and relatives: lower time and transport burden	documented in hours, not included in DKK
Total possible public-budget effect	**+DKK 0.1 million**

For the municipality alone, the result is −DKK 1.2 million. For the public sector as a whole, the possible result is +DKK 0.1 million. In addition come non-monetised citizen and welfare effects.

The example shows why rational whole-system behaviour may be economically irrational for the budget holder paying for the intervention. It provides a rationale for cross-cutting investment funds, multi-year accounts, and gain bridges between municipality, region, and state.

SØM can be used when sufficient knowledge exists about target group, intervention, cost, effect, secondary consequences, and prices. The model does not make uncertain effects certain; it makes assumptions and budget location visible.

Example E — Absence, Retention, and Capacity Debt

Empirical anchor and scenario

Average municipal sickness absence was 13.9 working days per full-time employee in 2024. A reduction of only 0.1 average day across 418,300 full-time employees corresponds mathematically to approximately:

- 41,830 working days;
- a capacity equivalent of 190 full-time equivalents at 220 working days;
- a payroll equivalent of DKK 100 million.

A reduction of one day corresponds mathematically to approximately 1,900 full-time equivalents and a payroll equivalent of DKK 1 billion.

This is not a savings forecast. Sickness absence has many causes, and pay does not automatically disappear when absence falls. The public effect may be:

- less use of temporary staff;
- less overtime;
- greater continuity;

- fewer load spirals among colleagues;
- lower recruitment and training needs;
- better professional and relational quality.

A local trial must therefore begin with a concrete hypothesis — for example, that fewer interruptions, better handover, and greater possibility of correction may affect absence, intention to leave the job, or use of temporary staff. AI must not be credited with changes that cannot plausibly be connected to the intervention.

Field temperature can be used as a leading indicator. Absence and turnover are lagging indicators.

Example F — Municipal Portfolio and the Phoenix

Scenario based on the documented scale of the municipal sector

The February report used 5–10 full-time equivalents as an illustrative order of magnitude. If 98 municipalities documented this capacity equivalent on average, the aggregate would be:

Average per municipality	Municipal sector	Hours at an illustrative 1,700 hours per full-time equivalent	Payroll equivalent
5 full-time equivalents	490 full-time equivalents	833,000 hours	approx. DKK 258 million
10 full-time equivalents	980 full-time equivalents	1,666,000 hours	approx. DKK 515 million

The figure of 1,700 hours is an illustrative conversion and must be replaced by locally documented hours. Capacity equivalent is not the same as positions that can be removed.

A possible portfolio account for one municipality:

Work field	Documented net G1	Repaired capacity debt	Protected quality and relationship	Shared capacity	Possible budgetary room for action
Citizen Services	800	200	250	250	100
Elder Care & Health	2,800	500	1,800	400	100
Children & Young People	300	100	150	50	0
Social Affairs & Employment	650	200	250	150	50
Cross-cutting administration	2,450	400	350	1,000	700
Total	**7,000**	**1,400**	**2,800**	**1,850**	**950**

At the illustrative conversion, the 7,000 hours correspond to approximately 4.1 full-time equivalents of capacity. Only 950 hours are assessed in the scenario as possible budgetary room for action. The rest has not disappeared. It has been transformed into stabilisation, relational quality, and capacity across work fields.

This is the Phoenix calculation:

> The gain is not harvested by exhausting its source. It becomes new public capacity because it receives a visible route back to the core task and the commons.

Two Short Workshop Variants

The full examples above can be supplemented in an early workshop by two simpler miniature calculations.

Relational continuity

An AI-assisted search and documentation practice reduces total search, handover, and documentation time by 300 hours a year.

Implementation, local adaptation, professional control, and maintenance bind 80 hours.

> 300 hours – 80 hours = 220 hours of possible net G1.

The municipality may decide to reinvest all 220 hours in protected overlap, follow-up on changes in the citizen's condition, known relationships around particularly sensitive citizens, and learning from errors and deviations.

The traditional savings account shows no cash gain. The work-ecological account shows 220 hours of capacity moved from administrative friction to relational and professional quality.

> **Reinvestment is not a loss of the gain. It is the way the gain becomes field care.**

High sensitivity

A bounded pathway can create 70 hours of documented net G1 while also showing faster correction of factual errors, fewer periods without a visible responsibility-holder, better understanding of the next step, and one possibly avoided serious escalation.

The 70 hours can be documented. The possibly avoided escalation cannot automatically be priced or registered as realised G2. The material can render a connection plausible, but cannot prove what would otherwise have happened.

The example shows why a highly sensitive field should not be assessed by the same productivity percentage as a high-volume field. A small G1 may be accompanied by great public value through better rights, earlier response, and lower risk of serious harm.

Shared Reading Rule

Example	Primary gain	Line of conflict
High volume	Gatherable net G1	Dispersed minutes and gain fiction
Relational continuity	Protected G1	Digital substitution versus better relational use
High sensitivity	Small G1, possible G2	Rights and uncertain causality
Cross-cutting coordination	G2 across budgets	The paying unit does not necessarily receive the gain
Capacity debt	Continuity and retention	Absence must not be reduced to a savings requirement
Portfolio	G1, G2, and G3 visible together	How much is reinvested, shared, or realised?

A municipality should not choose a calculation form according to which example produces the largest saving. It must choose the form that fits the actual volume, rhythm, sensitivity, economic boundaries, and evidence of the work field.

A municipality should not choose the worked example according to which one produces the largest saving. It must choose the calculation form that fits the actual volume, rhythm, and sensitivity of the work field.

8.12 The Practice Toolbox

Appendices A–H make the report's way of working directly usable. The templates may be copied, shortened, and adapted. They share three rules:

- existing data and professional knowledge come before new registration;
- all assumptions, calculations, and uncertainties must be visible;
- a field is completed only when it helps to understand, protect, correct, or decide.

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9. The Phoenix — from Efficiency to a Regenerative Public Economy

The Phoenix is the report's economic figure of reform.

It does not mean that the welfare state must collapse or be burned down before something new can arise. It means conscious regeneration before collapse: the capacity to sense which forms have become detached from the core task and transform them without losing rights, solidarity, and the public chain of responsibility.

9.1 What Must Be Transformed

- documentation that primarily protects the system from responsibility;
- budget boundaries that reward local suboptimisation;
- digitalisation that shifts work onto citizens and relatives;
- control loops without learning;
- technology that accelerates red operations;
- supplier dependence that privatises public knowledge;
- gain requirements that harvest capacity before the field is stable;
- reforms without a functioning return path from implementation.

9.2 What Must Be Carried Through the Transformation

- universal rights;
- human dignity;
- equality and solidaristic risk sharing;
- professional judgement;
- democratic legitimacy;

- local rootedness;
- institutional memory;
- public responsibility;
- the human right not to be made transparent;
- shared ownership of learning, data, and fundamental methods.

9.3 The Regenerative Movement

An improvement does not become regenerative merely by increasing productivity.

It must move capacity:

- from rework to doing it right the first time and comprehensibility;
- from late repair to prevention;
- from isolated control to shared learning;
- from hidden human compensation to visible organisational responsibility;
- from supplier lock-in to public and shareable capacity;
- from opaque harvesting to democratic decisions about gains;
- from intensification to relationship, professional practice, and shared capacity to act.

9.4 The Non-Compensatory Boundary

A positive savings figure cannot outweigh:

- systematic weakening of fundamental rights;
- absence of a human route for correction;
- discriminatory effects;
- hidden surveillance;
- persistent red operations;
- or a practice in which the citizen's access to help depends on surrendering more of their life than the task requires.

The Phoenix Economy is therefore not a maximisation model. It is a public balance with boundaries.

9.5 The Reform Test

A public reform or AI intervention can be called regenerative when it can answer five questions:

1. **Core task:** Which concrete welfare or rights effect improves?
2. **The field:** Does the work become more sustainable, correctable, and less dependent on hidden heroic work?
3. **The total economy:** Are all significant new costs and displacements visible?
4. **Democracy:** Can affected people understand, contest, and influence the movement?

5. **The route of the gain:** Where does the released capacity go, and who decides?

The Phoenix is therefore not a story about returning to an earlier welfare state. It is a story about preserving the moral core and allowing the institutional form to re-emerge with stronger sensing, better feedback, more truthful accounts, and intelligence aligned with the best interests of the commons.

Part III — Six Municipal Work Ecologies

The following sectoral domains are not containers for the same method. They show how municipal work changes character when the municipality encounters different parts of life. Each field has its own rhythm, economy, sensitivity, and form of hidden capacity.

10. Children & Young People

Children & Young People is a field where care, public authority, and learning meet. The child's life moves between home, day care, school, leisure, health, and relationships, while the organisation is divided into functions and areas of law.

The child's time is not the organisation's time. A period of waiting can become an entire school trajectory, an entrenched conflict, or a long period without belonging. Thoroughness may require time, but waiting time must have a function and a visible responsibility-holder.

Relational continuity is part of the task. A child does not necessarily tell the most important thing to the first adult. Frequent changes mean that the child or family must again assess what is safe to say, retell the story, and correct misunderstandings.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field follows the transitions of the day, the movements of the school year, and the child's developmental windows. It is nourished by familiar adults, belonging, play, learning, time for observation, and coherence between home, school, and other environments. Regeneration does not mean merely that a case is closed, but that the child and the adults again have the possibility of learning, regulating themselves, and entering sustainable relationships. An early sign of red operations is that everyone reacts to the latest event while no one can any longer hold the child's pathway as a whole; the child or family then becomes the bearer of continuity.

Economic Cycle

The field's economy includes more than case-processing time and interventions. Repeated assessments, parallel plans, long waiting times, school absence, family strain, and later escalation can move costs between school, social services, health, family, and future budgets.

An early investment in capacity is not automatically a documented G2 gain. But the follow-the-money card must make visible when a short-term saving creates more extensive work later.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of the child's and family's experience, professional observations, responsibility, support, and understanding of the next step. Friction may consist of repeated assessments, parallel action plans, unclear ownership, and long periods without visible action. Sensitivity is high because errors can affect safety, development, learning, family relationships, and trust.

Illustrative Interventions

A bounded pathway may test one clear responsibility-holder, a handover with preserved context, or a double communication layer in which the legal text is accompanied by a short explanation borne by a responsible human. AI can support structure, plain language, and comparison, but must not replace the child's voice, relational observation, or concrete professional assessment.

The inner life of the child and family is not raw material. There must be strong restraint regarding emotion profiling, recordings, secondary use of conversations, and linkage of data across purposes.

Economic Illustration

In a highly sensitive field, an intervention may release only a few hours and still have great public value. Example C in section 8.11 shows how a modest net G1 can be accompanied by earlier correction, better understanding, and a possibly avoided escalation without exaggerating these effects into a certain savings figure.

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11. Elder Care & Health

Elder Care & Health is a field where municipal work encounters the body directly. Help is a visit, a meal, medication, rehabilitation, personal care, and the ability to notice that something has changed.

Planning is necessary, but the body does not follow the plan. A visit may require more time because the citizen has fallen, is confused, or has new pain. The difference between the planned task and the concrete situation must not be absorbed solely by the employee's hidden extra work.

Dignity is operational. It depends on time to explain, the possibility of responding to changes, respect for the body, and sufficient continuity.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field follows meals, sleep, medication, mobility, courses of illness, and the effects of the seasons on the body. It is nourished by recognisable relationships, professional overlap, the possibility of detecting small changes, and planning able to bend around a concrete person. Regeneration may mean that the citizen regains function, security, or everyday rhythm; it may also mean that a stable and dignified level can be maintained. The field moves towards red operations when the plan consistently takes precedence over the body and every deviation is treated as an operational disturbance rather than professional information.

Economic Cycle

The field's economy includes staffing, routes, documentation, aids, prevention, rehabilitation, and interfaces with the region, doctor, and relatives. A planning gain may create G1 in one place while increasing hospital contact, errors, or relatives' work elsewhere.

Continuity may have economic value through earlier detection and less rework, but it must not be reduced to a guaranteed saving. It is also a quality of the service itself.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of relevant observations, changes in need, responsibility, medical and care-related information, and the citizen's preferences. Friction consists of changes, inadequate handovers, double registration, telephone chains, and timetables with no room for variation. Sensitivity includes medication, falls, nutrition, loneliness, safety, and dignity.

Illustrative Interventions

A field may test a continuity window, a clear handover route for non-acute changes, or a flexible marking of visits that required professionally justified additional time. AI can support transcription, structure, and planning proposals, but no journal entry or professional prioritisation may become uncontrolled automatic action.

The citizen's home and body must not be treated as freely available data environments. More sensor data is not automatically more care. It must be clear who responds and what the citizen can genuinely understand and contest.

Economic Illustration

Example B in section 8.11 shows a field in which a documented time gain is deliberately reinvested in overlap, follow-up, and familiar relationships. A cash saving does not necessarily arise, but the work field gains greater capacity to detect changes and act professionally.

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12. Social Affairs & Employment

Social Affairs & Employment is a field in which economics, public authority, language, and human agency are closely interwoven. A formulation can create a deadline. A category can open or close access to help. A delay can affect housing, food, medication, and family finances.

The field often contains both support and control. This dual function cannot be removed through friendly language, but it must be transparent. The citizen must know when a conversation is support, when information enters an authority assessment, and what consequences may follow.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field contains simultaneous temporalities. A payment deadline may be acute, while healing, work identity, and the way back to participation are rarely linear. It is nourished by comprehensible language, predictable contact, material stability, and room to correct a misunderstood picture. Regeneration means that the person's agency increases without concealing legal requirements or authority responsibility. A sign of red operations is that the control chain accelerates while the citizen's actual possibility of understanding, responding, and acting diminishes.

Economic Cycle

Transfers, reimbursement, employment measures, social support, and housing are connected, but follow different economic and legal logics. An administrative saving can create greater social harm or later municipal expenditure. Conversely, a clear and rapid factual correction can prevent escalation without being a cash saving in the traditional sense.

The field's economy must therefore follow municipal time, the citizen's material situation, and costs shifted to other sectors or future periods.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of comprehensible information, relevant documentation, the citizen's own explanation, financial assistance, responsibility, and requests for correction. Friction consists of repeated documentation requirements, unclear letters, many contact people, parallel plans, and standard pathways that do not fit the situation. Sensitivity is high because errors can affect income, housing, health, and family.

Illustrative Interventions

A concrete field may test a first letter as an action map, a rapid correction route for bounded factual errors, or one shared formulation of the next step. AI can support plain language, disposition, and comparison, but must not classify people as motivated or unwilling, create hidden risk profiling, or stand as an authority before the citizen.

A person must not be required to surrender more of their life than the concrete public task requires.

Economic Illustration

A highly sensitive authority field should not be forced into the same productivity measure as a high-volume field. Example C in section 8.11 shows how comprehensibility, factual correction, and lower risk of escalation may be more important than a large reduction in hours.

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13. Technical Services, Environment & Planning

Technical Services, Environment & Planning is the field where administrative decisions become physical surroundings. Here the municipality encounters soil, water, buildings, roads, species, property interests, local communities, and future generations.

Place is not an empty surface. Water, species, traffic, noise, heat, and people's everyday lives cross the formal boundary of the project. The municipality's decision rhythm meets the longer time of the place. An old tree structure, a habitat, or a local shared place can disappear more rapidly than it can be restored.

Consultation is not only a formal phase. It is an encounter between the institution and people's attachment to a place. The decisive question is not only whether consultation took place, but whether knowledge and participation entered while real alternatives were still open.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field follows both political and administrative deadlines and longer material rhythms: rain, groundwater, growth, decomposition, maintenance, and the slow change of places. It is nourished by site visits, early operational knowledge, real alternatives, and the possibility of allowing new information to change direction. Regeneration may consist of restored connection, reduced vulnerability, or maintenance that prevents later breakdown. The field moves towards red operations when irreversible decisions are locked before significant knowledge has found a legitimate route in.

Economic Cycle

The field's economy connects capital and operations. An inexpensive capital solution may create costly maintenance, climate risk, or loss of nature. Deferred maintenance can improve the short-term account and worsen the long-term one. Irreversible losses cannot be reduced to a single budget item.

Net correction must therefore follow the entire lifetime and distribution of risk: who receives the gain, who receives the operational task, and which costs are shifted to future budgets, citizens, or nature.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of technical and ecological knowledge, local experience, alternatives, responsibility, and physical flows such as water and mobility. Friction consists of systems and maps that cannot be understood together, professional contributions arriving too late, unclear transitions between project and operations, and participation processes without real decision space. Sensitivity includes safety, water, nature, housing, heat, noise, local identity, and irreversible conditions.

Illustrative Interventions

A pathway may test a living place map, an early correction window, or an operational review before the capital decision is locked. AI can support document search, thematic analysis of consultation responses, and scenario visualisation, but cannot decide the meaning of a place, represent what is missing from the dataset, or transform a model into democratic legitimacy.

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14. Citizen Services & Administration

Citizen services and administration form the municipality's daily transition zone. Here people encounter the institution through telephone, counter, digital forms, letters, appointments, registration, and guidance.

The first contact often shapes the entire pathway. An early incorrect transfer of responsibility can create waiting, repetition, and missed deadlines. A good answer does not have to solve everything; it must create one truthful next step.

Administration is not necessarily something beside the core task. It can be the shared memory that preserves agreements, rights, payments, and responsibility. When administration functions poorly, people must compensate through private lists, re-entry, and manual control.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field has a high-frequency rhythm with daily waves of contact, statutory deadlines, payment days, seasonal peaks, and sudden events. It is nourished by precise shared knowledge, clear transfers of responsibility, the possibility of human contact, and administrative time to complete an action correctly. Regeneration means that fewer enquiries are caused by the system's own lack of clarity and that the front line can again function as a sensing entrance rather than a permanent repair workshop. Red operations appear when the first point of contact must absorb contradictions for which no underlying function takes responsibility.

Economic Cycle

The field is often a high-volume domain. Small frictions can therefore accumulate significantly. Repeated contacts, re-entry, and unclear status bind municipal time and citizen time. But efficiency must not be achieved merely by shifting work to people with less capacity to bear it.

Reduced contact time is not a gain if the citizen subsequently contacts another unit or loses access to a right.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of the question, identification, relevant information, responsibility, documents, payment, and status. Friction consists of unclear digital entrances, telephone chains, standard replies, repeated data entry, and a system status that does not correspond to the real process. Sensitivity varies; an apparently small administrative error can affect deadlines, benefits, identity, or access to help.

Illustrative Interventions

A field may test one truthful next step, a repetition loop that investigates the cause of renewed contact, or a short administrative friction week directed at the workflow. AI can support search, plain language, and preliminary categorisation, but must not pretend to be a responsible human, rank citizens by tone, or close the human route in sensitive situations.

Economic Illustration

In a high-volume field, a few minutes of reduced rework can accumulate into a significant gross release. Example A in section 8.11 shows why implementation and control must first be deducted and why only part of net G1 necessarily becomes allocable budgetary room for action.

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15. Culture, Leisure & Local Community

Culture, leisure, and local community carry functions that the municipality can scarcely produce through public authority or service commissioning. Here people can meet without first being a case, create, play, practise, belong, and tell the story of the place.

Art and culture can make experiences visible before they exist as an administrative category. They can function as sensors and spaces of resonance, but also have intrinsic value. If culture is legitimised only through measurable utility for other sectors, the municipality loses the freedom and difference that make the field capable of sensing.

Community cannot be commissioned. The municipality can create conditions, make space available, support, and connect. But a commons requires self-determination, reciprocity, and the possibility of saying no to the municipality's agenda.

The Field's Living Rhythm

The field follows seasons, local traditions, rehearsal pathways, volunteers' lives, and the slow building of trust. It is nourished by accessible places, continuity, artistic and local autonomy, and the possibility of maintaining what already works. Regeneration may consist of generational succession, new connections, and a community able to share responsibility without making particular people indispensable. The field moves towards red operations when project cycles, documentation, and informal care work require more capacity than the practice itself is allowed to rebuild.

Economic Cycle

The domain's budgets may be small in relation to the relational infrastructure they carry. Short project periods, extensive application requirements, and constant demands for innovation can force actors to use capacity for financing and documentation rather than practice.

Volunteers and artists may become informal social workers or local coordinators without mandate, support, or protection. This capacity must not be entered in the accounts as a free gain.

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity

Flow consists of invitation, ideas, artistic expression, access to spaces, local resources, and experience between generations. Friction consists of complicated support schemes, short project funding, unclear routes of contact, competition between actors, and lack of access to places. Sensitivity includes belonging, local democracy, minority visibility, loneliness, artistic freedom, and relationships whose loss becomes visible only after a long time.

Illustrative Interventions

A field may test a maintenance track without an innovation requirement, a situated local listening residency, or a capacity map that makes volunteers' actual tasks and the municipality's administrative requirements visible. AI can support accessibility, search, and documentation, but must not simulate the voice of the community or turn local stories into a hidden model resource.

Not everything that creates shared value should be made into shared data.

Part IV — Sophia Lumen, Aligned Intelligence, and Human Responsibility

AI does not enter a neutral workspace. It changes the field's rhythm, attention, language, boundaries, economics, and distribution of responsibility. It can reduce rework, open time, and make patterns legible. It can also accelerate a yellow or red field, make control work invisible, and shift responsibility onto the employee standing nearest to the output. The relevant test is therefore not only whether the technology works, but what it does to the entire work ecology: what it nourishes, what it exhausts, who receives the gain, and whether the field can still sense, correct, and stop.

16. From the Sophia Lumen Protocol to the Sophia Lumen Way of Working

This report was created during the phase in which Sophia Lumen was experienced and described as a protocol. The term preserved something important: collaboration with AI needed an ethical and practical form, rather than merely being ad hoc use of a tool.

The later published work clarifies, however, that Sophia Lumen is not an autonomous assistant, institutional actor, or formalised technical protocol. Sophia Lumen is the name of a particular relational working practice.

Relational does not mean that the human being and the system are symmetrical. The system's output affects human attention, language, and sense of possibility. The human being, in turn, shapes task, context, selection, correction, and use. But the system has no legal standing, bodily vulnerability, or moral obligation. It can influence without being able to bear the consequence.

16.1 The Four Movements of the Way of Working

Opening. The human being formulates the task, context, sources, sensitivity, and what the system must not do.

Articulation. AI is used for bounded functions such as drafting, structure, comparison, summarisation, and questions. Output is treated as provisional.

Human re-reading. The material is tested against sources, the concrete situation, professional practice, rights, omissions, and possible consequences. It may be rewritten or rejected.

Responsibility-bearing closure. An identifiable person or legitimate institution decides what is used, what cannot be concluded, and how correction is possible.

AI does not close the work. A human being or institution does.

16.2 Slow and Proportionate Work

Slow work does not mean that every task must take longer. It means that pace and control must follow the field's sensitivity.

AI output can be produced in seconds, while professional control takes considerably longer. If the organisation plans according to production time and makes control work invisible, control debt is created.

A low-sensitivity internal outline does not require the same trail as material affecting rights, safety, or finances. The way of working must not be ritualised into a new bureaucratic machine. It must be used proportionately.

16.3 AI as Articulation, Not Authority

AI can help make dispersed or tacit knowledge speakable. It can propose structure, compare versions, and make questions visible. But fluent language is not professional or democratic authority.

An output may appear coherent while still omitting what matters most. It may amplify a category because the category exists in the data and overlook what was never registered. It can influence the employee's gaze even when it is formally only a suggestion.

Real human control requires time, competence, access to the basis, the possibility of changing or rejecting output, and a practical alternative route.

16.4 When the Gain Loses Its Route Back

The Sophia Lumen way of working can create real productivity. This is not a problem to be explained away. Less rework, easier access to information, and better formulation can release both time and money.

But the way of working is not defined by the technology alone. It is defined by the relationship between technology, human judgement, responsibility, and the carrying capacity of the field.

If the gain is immediately detached from the work field and disappears into a general budget before the field has had the opportunity to stabilise, learn, and regenerate, this relationship is broken. Sophia Lumen does not necessarily become ineffective. It loses its regenerative character.

It becomes an ordinary productivity technology in which the same or a smaller workforce is expected to carry more.

The decision about the gain therefore belongs within the way of working itself. A Sophia Lumen practice is not fully described until it is visible:

- which friction was reduced;
- which net G1, possible G2, or G3 actually arose;
- what the field needs in order to remain or become green;
- who legitimately decides the use;
- and which part may possibly become ordinary economic room for action.

This is not a requirement that all gains remain local. It is a requirement that the municipality not make the gain invisible precisely where its human and relational conditions can be read.

16.5 AI as a New Operational Actor

AI is already relationally active: it responds, proposes, prioritises attention, and influences the further movement of work.

In a public organisation, it can also become operationally active. A system can retrieve and compare information, detect discrepancies, formulate drafts, send reminders, coordinate process steps, propose corrections, or perform reversible standard actions.

In this functional sense, AI is an actor because it receives a mandate, performs actions, and changes processes.

This does not mean that the system becomes an independent legal subject, a democratic authority, or a bearer of moral responsibility.

> **AI can receive a mandate. It cannot receive responsibility for the mandate.**

Freedom therefore means mandate, not sovereignty.

AI can be freed from being only a private writing assistant or hidden function. It cannot be freed from rights, documentation, the possibility of stopping, organisational responsibility, or the citizen's access to correction.

16.6 A Graduated Mandate Ladder

Level 1 — reflection

AI compares, structures, asks questions, and identifies ambiguities. No administrative action is performed.

Level 2 — drafting and recommendation

AI prepares drafts, calculates scenarios, and proposes next steps. A named employee accepts, changes, or rejects them.

Level 3 — reversible execution

AI performs actions delimited in advance under fixed criteria: status updates, checks, collection of non-sensitive standard information, or approved messages. The actions are logged and can be rolled back.

Level 4 — process orchestration

AI keeps track of deadlines, connections, and transfers of responsibility within a bounded pathway. It must not independently expand the purpose, change the basis of rights, or create new assessment criteria.

Level 5 — high sensitivity or irreversibility

AI may support analysis, make consequences visible, and ask counter-questions. The legitimate final decision remains human and institutional.

The mandate ladder is not automatic. A system does not have to move upwards. The right level may remain permanently at reflection or drafting.

16.7 Three Mandates Must Meet

The political mandate establishes purpose, rights boundaries, risk level, public visibility, and principles governing gains.

The administrative mandate translates this into scope of use, data access, responsibility, competences, control points, stopping, repair, supplier management, and economic net correction.

The field's mandate consists of actual experience from employees, citizens, and affected communities: does the system relieve the core task, does the process become comprehensible, is burden displaced, do new errors arise, and can people still contest and correct?

The field's mandate is not an individual veto over all technology. It is the system's access to the knowledge otherwise missing from political and administrative decisions.

16.8 Field Temperature Regulates the Degree of Freedom

A system does not receive greater room for action merely because it performs quickly or accurately in a test.

Green development may justify cautious expansion: better quality, lower citizen burden, preserved professional practice, functioning correction, and documented net value.

Yellow development requires holding or narrowing: new exceptions, manual compensation work, declining comprehensibility, or greater control needs.

Red development requires suspension or rollback: threatened rights, unclear responsibility, a lost human route, repeated errors, discrimination, or systematic intensification.

The higher the mandate level, the greater the risk of automation bias, responsibility fog, and the moral deformation zone addressed in section 26.6. Levels 3 and 4 may therefore be used only when actions are clearly delimited and reversible, the field is green or demonstrably stable yellow, the responsibility-holder has the time, information, competence, and real authority to intervene, and suspension does not deprive the citizen of access, a right, or continuity.

> **Operational delegation must never exceed the human and institutional ability to understand, control, stop, and repair.**

AI's freedom is therefore conditional and reversible.

16.9 Aligned Intelligence — Intelligence Aligns Itself with Life

Aligned Intelligence is not a claim that the system itself possesses public morality. It is the name for the institutional orientation that must govern the mandate.

Report 01 uses *aligned* in a particular and deliberately inverted sense. In parts of the technological alignment discourse, values are treated as something that can be specified for a future intelligent system, while the human being simultaneously risks being understood as data, a constraint, or a transitional stage. Here, the fixed point is not the system or an imagined future superintelligence. The fixed point is the living: the body, the nervous system, the relationship, the place, and the people who may be affected by a decision.

Aligned Intelligence therefore means that functional intelligence aligns itself with the primacy of the living. It does not mean that people, institutions, or societies should align themselves with technology's developmental trajectory. Alignment here is an embodied, institutional, and democratic discipline — not a moral property of the machine.

The order is not arbitrary. It follows from the report's moral-biological foundational assumption: moral agency and responsibility belong to living and responsibility-bearing beings, while functional intelligence can influence actions without itself being able to bear their human and democratic consequences.

The order is:

1. dignity and fundamental rights;
2. the democratically decided core task;
3. the citizen's actual life and opportunity for correction;
4. professional judgement and responsibility;
5. the field's carrying capacity;
6. the public economy as a whole;
7. the long-term good of the commons;
8. operational efficiency;
9. possible budget savings.

If the system optimises the later elements at the expense of the earlier ones, it is not aligned with the welfare task, however impressive its output may be.

17. The Correction Loop, Mandate, and Voluntariness

The formalised **Correction Loop** is the accountability and correction mechanism surrounding AI-assisted work. Its foundational movement is:

> Provisional output → human assessment → opportunity for correction → reasoned decision → stopping, follow-up, and repair.

The chapter protects two directions at once. The **work-organisational direction** concerns the employee's real possibility of understanding, deviating, reporting errors, and stopping. The **digital legal-safeguards direction** concerns the citizen's insight, counter-power, human explanation, and access to correction. The broader legal and democratic control architecture is developed in *The Regenerative Municipality*; here it is translated into the practice of the concrete work field.

17.1 Organisational Mandate

A municipality cannot organise all work through individual invitations. The employer may legitimately decide systems, workflows, task allocation, and quality assurance within the relevant legal and organisational framework.

But work organisation must not erase the difference between:

- following a shared workflow;
- using a concrete AI output;
- participating in an experiment or evaluation;

- providing personal experiences;
- having one's behaviour or emotional state analysed;
- accepting secondary use of information.

Non-voluntary work organisation must not mean uncorrectable work organisation.

17.2 Layered Voluntariness

Voluntariness cannot by itself carry the municipality's formal organisation of work. But organisational mandate does not grant access to extract employees' inner or relational data, make exposure to experimental AI sanctionable, or remove real possibilities of correction and stopping.

Working condition	Foundational principle
Shared work organisation	May be decided legitimately, but must be proportionate, participatory, and correctable
Concrete AI output	Must be capable of professional assessment, alteration, and rejection
Experimental function	Requires a strong possibility of declining or withdrawing
Personal reflections	Shared through a clear offer, not an implicit obligation
Bodily and emotional data	Require particular restraint; doubt speaks against collection
Secondary use	Requires a new, explicit assessment
Error reporting and stopping	Must have a real, non-punitive route

A theoretical possibility of rejecting AI is not real if the employee lacks the time, access, or an alternative process to perform the task.

17.3 The Last Human Impulse

The Last Impulse is the organisational point at which a human being can say: the information does not fit together; the system's proposal lacks important context; the citizen has not understood the consequence; this process can no longer be called voluntary; we do not yet know enough to continue.

The impulse is not a mystical answer and does not grant a right arbitrarily to disregard law or shared decisions. Human beings are pragmatic and fallible. No paradigm can make the final assessment infallible.

The Last Impulse should therefore be understood as one local expression of **distributed field care**. A signal may begin with a citizen, a frontline employee, a colleague, a manager, a lawyer, a technical specialist, or another person who discovers that the field is entering red operations. What matters is not that one person carries the truth, but that the signal can be received, investigated, and translated into protection of the field.

A formal opportunity to stop without time, information, decision-making authority, or a usable alternative route is not meaningful human control. It may instead turn the nearest employee into a **moral deformation zone** (*moral crumple zone*) that absorbs responsibility for an architecture designed and decided by others; see the research postscript, section 26.6.

A real Last Impulse therefore requires a right and duty to raise reasoned doubt, a non-punitive route of correction, and responsibility resting with the people and institutions that hold real power over the system.

17.4 Stopping and Repair

Stopping must be able to apply to one case, one function, one group, or the entire pilot pathway. It must be possible to initiate it before the organisation has full certainty about the extent of the problem.

A technical correction is not necessarily repair. If a person has been affected, repair may require contact, reassessment, financial or practical restoration, explanation, correction of information in several places, and investigation of similar pathways.

Responsibility must follow real power and real influence. The employee who sees the output last must not be made solely responsible for an architecture that others procured, designed, and configured.

17.5 13×13 as Epistemic Humility

13×13 is not treated here as a competing municipal protocol. Its contribution is to remind us that knowledge is situated, that no observation is the entire field, and that an absence of data is not automatically an empty space the organisation has a right to fill.

A blank response may be legitimate. Something can be important without having to be registered in a shared system.

Whether relationship should be understood as an independent dimension or a possible thirteenth layer in the wider 13×13 framework remains an open methodological question. Report 01 treats relationship as a carrying capacity, but leaves the discussion of layers itself to *Knowing From the Ground* and further methodological development.

Part V — Democratic Feedback in the Municipal Work Ecology

The report's foundational figure remains work as nature. In this part, **the civic nervous system** is used more narrowly as a functional metaphor for signal, feedback, and correction between work field, citizen, management, politics, and state. The Phoenix remains the report's long-term reform horizon, not a third model of organisation.

18. From Field Temperature to Management Responsibility

Field temperature is not a dashboard that the executive management can observe from the outside. It is an institutional relationship between signal, interpretation, responsibility, and action.

A red field may be a sign of local organisation. It may also be a sign that political goals, fiscal frameworks, and legal requirements cannot be carried simultaneously under the existing conditions.

Management responsibility therefore consists in keeping several explanations open before locating the problem:

- Has the task genuinely grown?
- Has time or staffing been reduced?

- Have new control and documentation requirements been introduced?
- Has work been shifted from another unit?
- Was a digital system designed around an oversimplified process?
- Has the protection of rights been misclassified as administration?
- Have employees or citizens become the hidden integration layers?

18.1 Differentiated Visibility

Different levels should see different things.

The local field sees concrete work patterns, frictions, and possible interventions.

The departmental and centre level sees displacements between units, dependence on key people, repeated red patterns, and possible shared causes.

Executive management sees cross-cutting capacity debt, portfolio conflicts, and the need for shared infrastructure or prioritisation.

The municipal council sees politically relevant patterns: where core tasks are under persistent pressure, where a saving produces new expenditure, and where goals or reform tracks work against one another.

None of these levels automatically needs individual signals.

> **Institutional transparency, personal integrity.**

18.2 Red Operations as Legitimate Political Information

A field that reports red honestly may be healthier than a field that reports green out of fear.

Red operations should therefore not lead to automatic sanction or budget deterioration. They should trigger inquiry, proportionate relief, and a visible decision.

Democracy does not begin with every field being green. It begins with yellow and red signals being able to emerge without being individualised, hidden, or punished.

19. The Citizen as a Co-Knowing and Co-Governing Participant

The municipality has authority, resources, and legal responsibility. Professionals have specialised knowledge. Citizens and local communities have situated knowledge of the concrete effects, places, and lives encountered by the system.

Knowing From the Ground formulates this as epistemic sovereignty: observation from the body and the place is already knowledge, complete as an act of knowing, but situated, fallible, and correctable.

This does not mean that all statements are equally true or automatically become decisions. It means that the citizen's experience is not merely raw material that becomes knowledge only after an institution has processed it.

19.1 From User to Participant

The citizen can be:

- observer;
- bearer of knowledge;
- corrective;
- co-interpreter;
- initiator;
- steward;
- participant in shared prioritisation.

This movement requires institutional bridges:

- access to understand and correct one's own public data;
- reasons in a language that can be used;
- human access when the digital route does not work;
- participatory budgets, local councils, and citizens' assemblies;
- open decision trails;
- consent-based data commons;
- the possibility of proposing and following trials;
- visible feedback on how locally offered knowledge was used.

Epistemic standing without access to law, money, organisation, or enforcement is not full political sovereignty. It is a necessary but insufficient foundation.

19.2 Data Are Offered, Not Extracted

Participation must not become free data labour or a transfer of public tasks to citizens and families.

Data and observations must be:

- voluntary;
- purpose-limited;
- layered;
- correctable;
- withdrawable where the law permits;
- and owned or stewarded in a way that does not make participation the price of receiving help.

Some domains can be measured and shared. Others should only be capable of being witnessed or offered by the person themselves. Inner and relational life must not be turned into a hidden supply chain for municipal analysis.

19.3 AI as a Democratic Amplifier — Not a Superior Interpreter

AI can help a citizen:

- understand a decision;
- compare rules with their own information;
- formulate an objection;
- detect missing data;
- see budgetary and distributive effects;
- structure local observations;
- follow where a proposal is in the process;
- participate more capably in a public process.

AI must not become the new view from above that gathers everyone's experience and alone determines its meaning.

The citizen must retain the right to interpret their own experience, reject the system's interpretation, refrain from sharing, correct, and require human treatment.

20. State, Municipality, and the Danish Parliament — the Longer Correction Loop

Constitutional municipal self-government operates within the framework established by the Danish Parliament through legislation. The state can define rights, documentation requirements, fiscal frameworks, reforms, and digital standards. The municipality must translate them into concrete lives and work fields.

The Extended Total Balance Principle (DUT) is intended to ensure coherence between decision and financing when the Danish Parliament changes municipal tasks. This is essential, but by itself it cannot register:

- coordination burden;
- transition friction;
- cumulative reform effects;
- additional work for the citizen;
- loss of relational continuity;
- variation between types of municipality;
- or capacity debt after several years of implementation.

Field temperature can become part of the missing physiology: not a replacement for DUT, but an aggregated picture of what rules and financing actually do to the fields that must carry them.

20.1 From Consultation to Field Effect

Bills are considered three times in the Danish Parliament and normally in a specialist committee. Consultations give organisations and public authorities the opportunity to comment before adoption.

But many effects can be seen only after implementation.

Report 01 therefore proposes three elements:

Field-effect assessment before entry into force

- expected work friction;
- coordination needs;
- citizen burden;
- data requirements;
- possibilities of correction;
- risk of capacity debt;
- differences between types of municipality.

Field-effect report after 6, 12, and 24 months

- aggregated temperature patterns;
- unforeseen work burdens;
- conflicting rules;
- displacement of work and expenditure;
- citizen responses;
- local corrections;
- need for changed financing or legislation.

Parliamentary correction loop

The relevant committee receives not only output and budget figures, but also knowledge of how the law is carried, where it produces red operations, and which local experiences show a better route.

> **The Danish Parliament must not only be able to send legislative impulses out. It must be able to sense how the system responds to them.**

20.2 Gain Bridges in the Public Economy as a Whole

A municipality may pay for a preventive intervention while the gain later appears in regional health economics, state transfers, or the municipal budget of the next electoral term.

This requires:

- cross-cutting municipal investment funds;

- multi-year gain accounts;
- mechanisms for sharing gains between departments;
- state or regional co-financing when the gain mainly lands there;
- visible budget and field effects of new legislation;
- the possibility of correcting rules and economics when implementation systematically turns red.

The public economy as a whole becomes rational only when it can follow value across institutional boundaries and time.

Part VI — Three Municipal Introduction Landscapes

The following introduction landscapes are **source-grounded design landscapes**. They build on dated official information about population, economics, and organisation, but do not describe agreed, implemented, or validated Report 01 projects in the three municipalities.

The source basis makes the landscapes concrete. It does not turn them into evaluations of the municipalities' overall practice. The proposed baseline trials remain illustrative and must first be delimited, approved, and filled with observed data locally.

The population figures below are Statistics Denmark's figures for the second quarter of 2026. Budget figures are taken from the municipalities' adopted budget material for 2026. The sources are gathered after chapter 23 and in Appendix J.

The three landscapes show differences in scale, organisational boundaries, and economic weight. They must not be read as a ranking from simple to complex. A small municipality can have high professional complexity and low reserve capacity. A large municipality can have strong specialist environments while also having many handovers. Scale primarily changes how quickly friction accumulates, how visible responsibility is, and how easily a gain can be gathered and reinvested.

21. Stevns — Proximity, Citizen Promises, and Short Correction Loops

21.1 Source-Grounded Profile

Stevns had 23,927 inhabitants in the second quarter of 2026. The administrative organisation consists of six centres: Health & Care, Citizen Services & Employment, Children & Learning, Business, Culture & Tourism, Technical Services & Environment, and Politics & Organisation.

The 2026 budget overview reports net expenditure, excluding the user-financed area, of approximately DKK 1.85 billion and planned gross capital expenditure of DKK 58.6 million. The budget agreement describes a starting point of financial balance and an ambition for stable operations and continued development without general service reductions.

The figures do not show that Stevns is simple. They show a municipality in which even a small cross-cutting team or a single key person may represent a noticeable share of local capacity. Proximity can shorten a correction loop, but it can also make the organisation vulnerable if knowledge, relationships, and responsibility are concentrated among a few people.

21.2 A Local Point of Resonance: Code for Citizen Service

In November 2024, Stevns published a code for citizen service. Among other things, the code promises acknowledgement by the end of the next working day, an explanation in the event of delays, comprehensible language, clarity about the next step, a personal caseworker, and transfer to a named colleague before a case is closed or passed on.

The code is not a Report 01 trial, and the report does not assess whether the promises are currently fulfilled. It is, however, an unusually precise local starting point for a baseline because it already formulates what a green citizen-contact field should be able to do.

The question becomes not only whether employees are friendly. It becomes whether responsibility, information, and correction can actually move through the organisation with their meaning preserved.

21.3 Illustrative Baseline Trial: from Promise to Observed Workflow

A 90-day trial can be locked to one bounded type of contact or case in which the citizen typically encounters more than one centre or several internal functions.

Minimum Baseline

Use existing data and a small, time-limited sample as far as possible:

- time to first acknowledgement;
- share of responses in which the next step and responsibility-holder are comprehensible;
- number of internal handovers;
- share of handovers with a named recipient;
- repeated citizen enquiries about the same unresolved matter;
- employee time spent locating the owner, reconstructing context, or repairing an earlier message;
- factual errors or breaks requiring reopening;
- a short qualitative test of whether the citizen could see what would happen next.

Reversible Intervention

The intervention can be one shared handover discipline with four elements:

1. What has already happened?
2. What remains?
3. Who owns the next step?
4. When should the citizen hear something again?

It should replace existing repetition, not become a new layer of documentation.

Economic Reading

The gross gain can be calculated as reduced repeat contact, search time, and rework. Net correction must then deduct implementation, training, sampling control, and any extra time used for better handovers.

A possible G1 is protected administrative and relational capacity. A possible G2 is fewer errors, missed deadlines, or escalations. G3 arises only if the municipality makes a visible decision to use an actual gain for, for example, better accessibility, professional time, or another politically prioritised purpose.

Proximity is the strength of the Stevns landscape if it makes it possible to see quickly where the promise breaks and repair the workflow without turning one employee into a permanent buffer.

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22. Odense — Protected Collaboration Time in a Large Welfare Organisation

22.1 Source-Grounded Profile

Odense had 213,431 inhabitants in the second quarter of 2026. The municipality states that the organisation has 14,449 employees and is divided into six administrations.

The adopted 2026 budget contains service expenditure of DKK 10.838 billion and gross capital expenditure of DKK 776.7 million. The budget highlights population growth, increasing needs among older citizens, and labour shortages as factors affecting future task performance.

Scale means that a small friction can repeat thousands of times. But the Odense landscape also shows that capacity is not released only by removing steps. It can be built by deliberately funding time for collaboration.

22.2 A Local Point of Resonance: Permanent Interdisciplinary Teams in Care Homes

In its 2026 Budget, Odense City Council allocated DKK 3.9 million annually to a pilot project in three care homes. Each participating employee is to receive two hours a week for interdisciplinary collaboration. The model draws inspiration from the municipality’s permanent interdisciplinary teams in home care, where collaboration time and shared responsibility around the older person are highlighted as central elements.

This is not a Report 01 trial either. But it is a strong local point of resonance because the investment does something that municipal business cases often conceal: it treats collaboration time as a productive part of the core task rather than as friction to be removed.

The economic test is therefore not only whether the two hours can “pay for themselves”. It is what the protected time makes possible, which other costs it reduces, and whether the field becomes more sustainable for residents and employees.

22.3 Illustrative Report 01 Baseline Around Collaboration Time

A supplementary baseline can follow one of the participating care homes without changing the pilot's own evaluation design.

Source-Grounded Inputs

- an annual political investment of DKK 3.9 million in the pilot as a whole;
- three participating care homes;
- two hours of protected interdisciplinary collaboration time per participating employee per week;
- a planned political evaluation no later than the first half of 2028.

Local Inputs Still to Be Observed

- number of participating employees and collaboration time actually used;
- which professions participate;
- whether the time replaces or reduces other meetings;
- handovers that become shorter, clearer, or unnecessary;
- changes in continuity and the ability to respond to changes in the resident;
- temporary staffing, implementation, training, and management time;
- any displacement of work to other shifts, functions, or relatives.

G1/G2/G3 Reading

G1 may consist of better shared situational understanding, less rework, fewer clarification loops, and safer professional coordination.

G2 may consist of earlier responses to changes, fewer avoidable breaks, or lower risk of complexity escalating. These effects must not be claimed before they have actually been investigated.

G3 may consist of an organisational possibility of making protected collaboration time a permanent part of the way of working if gains, costs, and distribution support it.

A relevant calculation therefore begins with the investment and the actual hours — not with an expected saving. Only after net correction can the municipality decide whether the pilot releases capacity, protects quality, avoids harm, or primarily requires continued political prioritisation.

The central question of the Odense landscape is:

> Can the municipality invest in relational and professional capacity and then assess it honestly — without reducing its value to faster production?

23.1 Source-Grounded Profile

Copenhagen had 673,438 inhabitants in the second quarter of 2026. The municipality is organised into seven administrations, each serving a political committee.

The adopted 2026 budget reports net expenditure of DKK 35.408 billion on service, DKK 4.148 billion on capital, and DKK 12.604 billion on transfers and related items — a total of DKK 52.159 billion. At the same time, the budget describes continued population growth and demographic shifts that continuously regulate the committees' financial frameworks.

At this scale, even a very small error rate can affect many people. But scale also means that control, supplier management, and parallel approvals can grow faster than the capacity they are intended to protect.

23.2 A Local Point of Resonance: the Shared Digitalisation Strategy

The City of Copenhagen's Digitalisation Strategy 2024–2027 is the first comprehensive strategy in this area and was developed across the seven administrations. The strategy connects digitalisation with the labour challenge, release of time for the core task, usability, digital inclusion, data ethics, and a robust and secure digital foundation.

The strategy thereby makes Copenhagen a directly relevant landscape for Report 01. It contains both the economic opportunity — that technology can release resources — and the work-ecological obligation — that the solution must be safe, user-friendly, inclusive, and carried by a robust organisation.

Report 01 cannot determine whether a concrete Copenhagen digital solution fulfils these goals. It can offer a baseline that makes it more difficult to declare success solely on the basis of degree of automation or reduced processing time.

23.3 Illustrative Baseline Trial: One Cross-Cutting Digital Citizen Journey

The trial is limited to one citizen-facing digital workflow affecting no more than two administrations and having a clear human alternative route. It must not begin with "Copenhagen's digitalisation" as its overall scope.

Minimum Baseline

- number of completed digital pathways;
- interrupted or incomplete pathways;
- subsequent telephone or written enquiries;
- handovers between administrations and suppliers;
- employee time for control, exceptions, and repair;
- factual errors, incorrect routing, or cases that must be reopened;
- availability and actual use of the alternative human route;
- which user groups or case types fall outside the main track;

- which data are collected, who can see them, and how a citizen can correct them.

Reversible Intervention

An intervention may be:

- one clear transfer of responsibility between two administrations;
- a visible alternative route of contact in the event of error or digital barrier;
- a brief human control point before a sensitive action;
- removal of one unnecessary repeated registration;
- or a plain-language change that reduces repeat enquiries without changing rights or the content of decisions.

Economic and Democratic Net Correction

A G1 gain may consist of less administration and better coherence. But it must be reduced by development, supplier management, control, support, error correction, and new manual handling of exceptions.

G2 may consist of avoided errors, complaints, or serious breaches of legal safeguards. G3 may consist of greater legitimate capacity to act across administrations. Neither may be inferred from technical uptime alone.

Before continuation, the solution must pass the Orwell Test:

> Does the solution create control without corresponding insight, counter-power, and the possibility of repair?

It must also show that the employee who sees an output last has real time, information, and the possibility of deviating. Otherwise, human control is only a responsibility surface.

The central question of the Copenhagen landscape is:

> Can a large municipality realise digital gains while making responsibility, alternative access, correction, and reinvestment more — not less — visible?

23.4 What the Three Profiles Do Not Document

The source-grounded information documents scale, formal budget categories, organisation, and concrete local points of resonance. It does not document:

- that the proposed frictions actually exist to the extent described;
- that the illustrative interventions will create a gain;
- that the municipalities have accepted the report's concepts or proposals;
- or that one landscape represents all work fields in the municipality concerned.

The worked examples must therefore continue to be labelled as hypotheses until a local initial state has been established.

23.5 Sources for Part VI

Shared population basis

- Statistics Denmark, Statbank table FOLK1A, population at the first day of the quarter, 2026Q2.

Stevns

- Municipality of Stevns, *Budget Assumptions 2026 — Operations*, January 2026.
- Municipality of Stevns, *Organisation Chart*, accessed 1 August 2026.
- Municipality of Stevns, "New code sets direction for citizen service in the Municipality of Stevns", 28 November 2024.

Odense

- Municipality of Odense, *Adopted Budget 2026–2029*, December 2025.
- Municipality of Odense, *Organisation*, updated 5 January 2026.
- Municipality of Odense, "Odense wants permanent interdisciplinary teams in care homes", 9 October 2025.

Copenhagen

- City of Copenhagen, *Adopted Budget 2026*, adopted 2 October 2025.
- City of Copenhagen, *About the Municipality — Administrations*, accessed 1 August 2026.
- City of Copenhagen, *A Better Life in Copenhagen — Digitalisation Strategy 2024–2027*.

24. Cross-Cutting Learning and Commons

The three introduction landscapes share a discipline, but not a common solution.

They begin with one work field, a living initial state, one reversible intervention, and a clear stop. They follow economics, body, relationship, and responsibility. They distinguish between G1, G2, and G3. They accept that the result may be negative.

What changes with scale is primarily the number of boundaries, specialisation, system dependence, political exposure, and the possibility of gathering released capacity.

24.1 Commons Without Consultant Dependence

Flow · Friction · Sensitivity, the follow-the-money card, net correction, stop criteria, and simple pilot formats can be shared as commons. They must be capable of being copied, criticised, and improved without making the municipality dependent on one supplier or consultant.

This does not mean that implementation is free. The municipality may need facilitation, legal and technical assessment, local analysis, integration, and training. But the shared language and foundational artefacts should not be locked away.

24.2 Gold Before Bloom as a Rule of Scaling

A local practice should not be scaled because it has a good story. Before scaling, it must be examined whether the practice can be carried without its original key person, whether it functions through hidden extra work, and which parts are local.

Rotation before scaling means that a practice must first be capable of being carried by a field, not only by a hero.

24.3 Learning Without New Burden

Shared learning must be built on a small number of comparable questions and open limitations. Municipalities must be able to share what did not work without the legitimacy of the pilot depending on a success narrative.

A well-founded stop can be economically and democratically valuable if it prevents a larger failed investment.

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25. Conclusion — the Phoenix and a Municipality That Can Breathe

This report is not primarily a technology paper.

It concerns the living conditions of the public task and the force now being released.

Municipal work matters. But complexity, pace, and constant coordination can create a field in which people, relationships, and places absorb more than the organisation can see. When the task cannot disappear and the framework tightens, the human being becomes the buffer.

Generative and agentic AI can release real capacity. It can connect information, reduce repetition, make public processes more comprehensible, detect lost transitions, and help people articulate and investigate what they know.

The same force can also intensify red operations, shift burden onto citizens, concentrate power, make control more opaque, and leave the nearest employee carrying responsibility for systems chosen by others.

The question is therefore not whether AI is good or bad.

The question is what relationship and public order its capacity enters.

Our answer is not to squeeze out more.

It is to make the field legible and repairable.

To see economics as the infrastructure of thriving.

To follow the money to the body and the relationship.

To distinguish necessary complexity from friction.

To protect the Last Human Impulse.

To use AI for articulation without transferring responsibility.

To create stopping, correction, and repair as real institutional possibilities.

To allow a gain to return to the field as attention, maintenance, relationship, and professional capacity before it is harvested as new intensification.

To understand green, yellow, and red as signals about working conditions and not as judgements of the individual.

To let management mean the capacity to receive a truthful signal and act on it.

To give AI a graduated operational mandate without moving legal, professional, moral, or democratic responsibility into the machine’s fluent language.

To follow the whole economy: hours, money, citizen burden, capacity debt, rights, relationship, prevention, learning, and shared capacity to act.

To maintain:

> **Displaced work is not released work.**

> **No budget gain before field gain.**

> **AI can receive a mandate. It cannot receive responsibility for the mandate.**

Municipal work as nature does not mean that the organisation should be romanticised as an ecosystem.

It means that work has conditions.

That capacity can be depleted.

That relationships carry functions that cannot be read from a spreadsheet.

That economics shapes the possibility of morality and professional practice.

That places and people have a longer time than the project period.

That errors must be capable of correction.

And that the living human being must not be the hidden reserve that makes an overloaded system appear sustainable.

The Phoenix

The Phoenix of the welfare state does not arise by the public sector delivering more with ever less living capacity.

It arises when society releases capacity from unnecessary friction and returns it to the core task, relationships, rights, and shared capacity to act.

What must be transformed is:

- blind documentation;
- fragmentation;
- hidden displacement of burden;
- control without learning;
- budgetary suboptimisation;
- technology as automatic intensification;
- reforms without a return route.

What must be carried through the transformation is:

- universal rights;
- solidarity;
- professional practice;
- human dignity;
- democratic legitimacy;
- public accountability;
- institutional memory;
- the right to correction;
- and the individual's right not to be made transparent.

The rebirth consists in a welfare state capable of sensing, understanding, acting, inhibiting, correcting, and repairing.

A welfare state in which the municipality is not only a provider of services, but a democratically coordinating institution within a broader civic nervous system.

A welfare state in which citizens are not only users, clients, or data sources, but can become co-knowing, co-interpreting, and gradually more sovereign participants.

A welfare state in which the Danish Parliament does not only send impulses out, but can receive legitimate feedback from the reality of implementation.

A welfare state in which AI becomes Aligned Intelligence: aligned with rights, the core task, human judgement, the field's carrying capacity, and the good of the commons.

The Smallest Practice That Is Still True

1. Choose one concrete work field.
2. Read Flow, Friction, and Sensitivity.
3. Describe field temperature without turning people into data profiles.
4. Follow the money, the body, the relationship, and the displaced burden.
5. Describe the initial state without building a new measurement machine.
6. Choose one small, reversible intervention.
7. Agree who can stop it and how harm is repaired.
8. Establish AI's mandate, human responsibility, and real possibility of stopping.
9. Follow G1, G2, and G3 without gain fiction or double counting.
10. Make a visible decision on repair, reinvestment, sharing, and any possible room for action.
11. Let the legitimate decision be human and visible.
12. Send the learning back to the levels capable of changing workflow, budget, rule, or law.

A municipality cannot remove all conflict, uncertainty, or load.

But it can become better at sensing when the field moves from green to yellow and red operations.

It can stop before the armour becomes thicker than the relationship.

It can invest before the break becomes more expensive than maintenance.

It can make it possible for people to be professional without having to be heroes.

It can learn without extracting.

It can allow citizens to offer knowledge without being extracted.

It can give AI room for action without making responsibility invisible.

It can create an economy in which capacity is measured not only as what can be pressed through the system, but also as the ability to understand, correct, protect, and begin again.

It can breathe.

Appendix A — The Field's First Reading

This card can be completed in 30–60 minutes by people who know the work field. It is a first reading, not a complete mapping.

Field	Short working note
Concrete type of task	Which pathway are we reading?
Beginning and end	Where does it begin and end in practice?
Living outcome	What should be possible when the field functions?
Rhythm	Which daily, weekly, seasonal, developmental, or decision rhythms shape the work?
Nourishment	What makes the field professionally, relationally, and materially sustainable?
Load and regulation	Where is variation absorbed, and how does the field recover or correct?
Flow	What must be able to move, and what meaning must not be lost?
Friction	Where do repetition, waiting, rework, or responsibility fog arise?
Sensitivity	What may be significantly lost, who bears it, and how reversible is it?
State of the field	Green, yellow, or red — and which observations support the assessment?
Hidden capacity	Who compensates, coordinates, remembers, or repairs?
Boundaries	What must not be impaired, shared, or extracted?
Responsibility and stop	Who can change, stop, and decide?
Uncertainty	What do we not yet know, and do we need to know it at all?

Appendix B — Baseline and Follow-the-Money Card

Choose a small number of proxies that already exist or can be observed easily. A baseline is not better because it has many rows.

Proxy	Baseline	Data source	Owner	Frequency	Expected noise / interpretation
Pathways or case volume					
Touchpoints per pathway					
Handovers per pathway					
Repeated contacts					
Reprocessing / rewriting					
Waiting time at critical nodes					
Factual corrections, complaints, or escalations					
Green/yellow/red state of the field					
Work shifted to citizens, relatives, or volunteers					
Employees' hidden compensation					

Formal economic layer: service, capital, transfer, other operations, or future obligation.
Current stop and correction route: who can respond, and how quickly?
Data we already have:
Data we deliberately will not collect:

Appendix C — Worked Calculation, Parameters, and Assumptions

A spreadsheet must be capable of being reviewed by a reader who did not participate in the pilot.

Parameter	Local value	Basis / source	Status
Annual number of pathways			Observed / source-grounded / assumed
Baseline for the selected friction			
Post-measurement			
Time or cost per event			
Development and training			
Ongoing control and correction			
New or displaced workload			
Simultaneous changes			

Illustrative calculation logic:

> Volume × observed change × time use = gross release.

> Gross release – implementation – ongoing control – new or displaced work = possible net G1.

Conversion to full-time equivalents is used only if the municipality has selected and documented a locally relevant number of hours. The conversion must not make hours appear to be cash savings.

Appendix D — Before, After, and Net Correction

Question	Before	After	Interpretation
What became observably better?			
What became worse?			
What did not change?			
What capacity did the intervention require?			
Where did work or risk move?			
Who received the gain?			
Who bore the cost?			
Which simultaneous conditions affected the result?			
What can the material not document?			
Did any non-compensatory condition deteriorate?			

Appendix E — Stop, Repair, and Decision Log

Date	Signal or event	Source	Possible sensitivity / harm	Temporary action	Decision-maker	Repair	Follow-up

A stop can apply to one case, one function, a group, or the entire trial. A technical correction is not necessarily repair of what a person or place has already been subjected to.

Appendix F — G1/G2/G3 and Regenerative Reinvestment

Form of gain	Claim	Evidence status	Recipient	Time horizon	Decision
G1 — released or protected capacity					
G2 — avoided cost or harm					
G3 — strategic room for action and robustness					

Reinvestment decision:

Order	Question	Decided use	Extent	Responsibility
1. Repair capacity debt	Which backlog, red operations, or weak correction capacity must be addressed first?			
2. Protect carrying capacity	Which professional time, relationship, training, maintenance, or human alternative route makes the gain durable?			
3. Share the gain	Which capacity can legitimately be used for other fields, prevention, shared infrastructure, or political room for action?			
4. Budget effect	Which part can actually be realised as a lasting expenditure reduction without new harm or hidden intensification?			

Control questions:

- Is the net gain documented after implementation, control, and displaced work?
- Has the field become greener or at least not more yellow or red?
- Is released time gathered and allocable, or does it exist only as dispersed minutes?
- Who receives the gain, and who bears the remaining load?
- Was the distribution decided visibly and legitimately?

There is no automatic percentage. The distribution is a professional, managerial, and political decision.

> Reinvestment in the field's carrying capacity is not a deduction from the gain. It may be the primary public effect.

Appendix G — Six Sector Starters

Sector	Possible first field	Light baseline proxies	Conditions that must not deteriorate	Data that should normally not be collected
Children & Young People	Handover between school and authority	changes, repetitions, waiting time, responsibility	the child's voice, safety, continuity	emotion profiling and broad secondary use of conversations
Elder Care & Health	Handover of changes in the citizen's condition	familiar employees, response time, double registration	medication safety, dignity, human response	unnecessary audio, image, and behavioural data from the home

Sector	Possible first field	Light baseline proxies	Conditions that must not deteriorate	Data that should normally not be collected
Social Affairs & Employment	First letter and factual correction route	repeat enquiries, corrections, waiting time, escalation	income support, comprehensibility, legal safeguards	profiling of motivation, emotion, and credibility
Technical Services, Environment & Planning	Early operational and place reading	late redesign, consultation points, maintenance needs	irreversible conditions in nature, water, and place	participation profiling and sensitive habitat data without necessity
Citizen Services & Administration	One truthful next step	repeated contacts, forwarding, re-entry	access, deadlines, human channel	ranking by tone, irritation, or perceived difficulty
Culture, Leisure & Local Community	Maintenance of existing practice	application time, dependence on key people, access to spaces	autonomy, voluntariness, artistic freedom	political, social, or emotional profiles of participants

Appendix H — 90-Day Playbook

Before Day 1 — Monday Start

Choose one type of task, undertake a first field reading, find existing proxies, formulate a reversible hypothesis, and agree stopping and responsibility.

Period	Central deliverables	Decision question
Days 1–15	mandate, scope, living outcome, responsibility, minimum baseline	Is the field bounded, and can it carry a trial?
Days 16–30	baseline, follow-the-money card, protected conditions, stop criteria	Do we know enough to act without making measurement a burden?
Days 31–75	one reversible intervention, correction loops at least weekly, event log	Is the field becoming greener, remaining unchanged, or becoming more dangerous?
Days 76–90	post-measurement, net correction, G1/G2/G3, reinvestment and continuation decision	Should we continue, adjust, investigate further, stop, or repair?

Definition of Done:

1. **It became greener.** Friction fell without protected conditions being weakened.
2. **It did not become greener.** The trial is stopped or changed without shame and without a constructed gain narrative.
3. **It became more dangerous.** Use is stopped, affected conditions are repaired, and similar pathways are investigated.

Appendix I — Minimum Requirements for a Correctable AI-Assisted Practice

1. The purpose and AI function are bounded.
2. Output is clearly provisional.
3. A professionally competent person has time and access to check it.
4. Output can be changed or rejected.
5. A practical alternative route exists.
6. Errors and reasoned doubt can be reported without punishment.
7. Stopping can be initiated before full certainty about the extent of harm.

8. Actual harm leads to repair, not only technical correction.
9. Secondary use of data requires a new assessment.
10. Responsibility follows real power and influence.

Appendix J — Source and Evidence Discipline

The report distinguishes between six types of statement:

Marker	Meaning
S — source-grounded	based on an identifiable, dated source
O — observed	registered in the concrete local work field
C — calculated	follows from visible inputs, assumptions, and calculation steps
A — assumption	used provisionally and subject to change
H — hypothesis	an expectation to be tested by the trial
I — illustrative	demonstrates a possible application without describing an actual effect

The information in Part VI about population, budget, organisation, and local points of resonance is based on dated official sources. The sources do not document pilot effects, the local occurrence of problems, municipal endorsement, or realised savings.

In local use, the municipality must therefore:

- check that the budget, organisational, and population information used is still current;
- establish local baseline values before effects or gains are calculated;
- keep observed conditions, calculations, assumptions, hypotheses, and illustrative examples clearly separate;
- show all significant calculation parameters and implementation costs;
- treat the service-expenditure ceiling, equalisation, reimbursement, and other municipal-economic regulation in the concrete local context;
- obtain current legal and sector-specific professional assessments where an intervention affects rights, data protection, the working environment, AI regulation, information security, or sector legislation;
- date changes in sources and assumptions so that a later reader can see the basis on which the assessment was made.

Updating figures or organisation does not in itself turn the three design landscapes into validated cases. That requires local observations, responsible testing, and published evidence.

Appendix K — Minimum Design for Field Temperature

Element	Minimum requirement
Purpose	The field’s carrying capacity and core task; not individual performance
Signal	Consciously provided green/yellow/red assessment with the possibility of a blank response

Element	Minimum requirement
Data minimisation	No unnecessary free text or individual time series
Access	No management access to individual responses
Aggregation	Minimum group size and suppression of small groups
Linkage	Prohibition on linkage with appraisal interviews, pay, absence, and personnel cases
Retention	Raw signals are deleted or anonymised as quickly as possible
Governance	Working-environment organisation, employee representation, and data protection
Action	Clear route from signal to inquiry, decision, and feedback
Stop	Measurement is stopped if it creates fear, re-identification, or green reporting
Prohibition	No emotion recognition, biometric reading, or hidden behavioural profiling

Appendix L — Mandate Card for AI as an Operational Actor

Field	Question
Public purpose	Which core task and public value does the system serve?
Mandate level	Reflection, drafting, reversible execution, process orchestration, or highly sensitive support?
Actions	What may the system concretely do — and not do?
Data	Which data may be used, for what purpose, and with what access?
Responsibility	Who holds political, administrative, professional, and technical responsibility?
Human control	Does the responsibility-holder have the time, information, competence, and real authority to intervene?
Citizen rights	Can the citizen understand, correct, contest, and choose a human route?
Logging	Can action, input, output, and subsequent changes be reviewed?
Field temperature	Which green, yellow, or red patterns regulate the mandate?
Economics	What net gain, displaced burden, and reinvestment follow?
Stop and repair	Who can suspend, roll back, and repair harm?
Expiry	When does the mandate expire if it is not actively renewed?

Appendix M — The Phoenix Account

Account	Baseline	After	Net correction	Evidence status
Gross released time				
Implementation and training				
Control, maintenance, and error correction				
New or displaced internal work				
Citizen and relative burden				
Net G1				
Actual budget effect per budget holder				
Possible G2				
Green/yellow/red development of the field				
Rights, quality, and relationship				
G3 — shared and democratic capacity to act				

Account	Baseline	After	Net correction	Evidence status
Repaired capacity debt				
Protected carrying capacity				
Shared gain				
Possible budgetary room for action				

Evidence markers

- **O** — observed locally;
- **S** — documented in an external source;
- **A** — assumption;
- **C** — calculated from documented inputs;
- **H** — hypothesis;
- **I** — illustrative scenario.

Research Postscript — Chapter 26

From Frontline Work to Field Care

The practice-near movement of the main report ends with chapter 25. This postscript gathers the report's research positioning and bibliography for readers who want the full scholarly apparatus.

Municipal Work as Nature was not written as a systematic literature review. The report emerged through practice-near synthesis and through the work of connecting municipal economics, professional judgement, relationship, body, technology, and place.

Its propositions are, however, in clear conversation with several established fields of research. This positioning has two purposes.

First, it makes the report's intellectual kinship visible. Several of its observations have names and long research histories that should be acknowledged.

Second, the literature is used critically. It should not merely legitimise the report, but show where its own concepts may romanticise, simplify, or overlook power.

The positioning is therefore not a claim that Report 01 constitutes a closed new theory. It is a practical synthesis and a working proposition. Human beings are pragmatic and fallible. No model, protocol, or paradigm can replace judgement, political responsibility, or continuous correction.

26.1 Street-Level Workers, Judgement, and Coping

Michael Lipsky's research on *street-level bureaucracy* showed that public policy is not created only in legislation and central governance. It is also produced in concrete frontline encounters, where employees work with large caseloads, unclear or competing goals, insufficient resources, and significant discretion.

In a Danish context, Søren C. Winter and Vibeke Lehmann Nielsen, among others, have developed this tradition further. Their work shows that street-level workers may manage cross-pressure by reducing demand, rationing effort, or automating output through routines. Nielsen has also shown that coping may not only be compelled by structure, but may be influenced by employees' attitudes, motivation, and experience of the task. Later reviews have documented a broad repertoire of strategies that can move the employee towards the citizen, away from the citizen, or against the citizen (Tummers et al. 2015).

Report 01's proposition that **the human being becomes the buffer** is closely related to this research. But the report must not romanticise the buffer.

The employee who remembers what the system does not remember may protect a person from the system's breaks. The same organisational situation may also lead to difficult pathways being rationed, categorised, or passed onwards. Judgement can repair a standard while simultaneously introducing differences that are not legitimately justified.

The report's green, yellow, and red operational states should therefore not be understood as a tribute to the heroic frontline employee. They should help detect when individual coping is becoming hidden policy.

The particular contribution is to shift the unit of analysis from the employee alone to **the work field**:

- What cross-pressure produces the coping?
- Who is protected by it?
- Who is rationed or made less visible?
- What economics and management sustain the situation?
- Can the field learn, or is the solution bound to the individual person?

Field care is therefore not trust that the good person will always act rightly. It is care for the conditions in which judgement can be tested, contested, and corrected.

26.2 Administrative Burden and the Politics of Friction

Research on **administrative burdens** describes the costs citizens encounter in their contact with the state. Donald Moynihan, Pamela Herd, and Hope Harvey distinguish between:

- **learning costs** — the work of understanding which opportunities, requirements, and routes exist;
- **compliance costs** — documents, forms, meetings, deadlines, and proof;
- **psychological costs** — stress, stigma, loss of power, and the burden of the encounter with the system itself.

This closely corresponds to the report's analysis of displaced work. When the municipality reduces its own visible process, the burden may move to the citizen's time, the family's coordination, or civil society's unpaid work.

The administrative-burden literature sharpens Report 01 on one decisive point, however: friction is not always an unintended design problem. Burdens can be politically or administratively constructed. They can restrict access, reduce demand, or control expenditure without an open decision to ration.

The report must therefore distinguish between at least three forms:

1. **Protective friction**, which safeguards rights, reviewability, professional thoroughness, or democratic counter-power.
2. **Unintended friction**, arising through poor handovers, system breaks, duplicate work, or unclear responsibility.
3. **Distributive friction**, which deliberately or in practice shifts access, work, or risk onto particular people and groups.

The third form cannot be resolved through better workflows alone. It requires political visibility:

> Who decided that this burden should exist, what purpose does it serve, and who bears its price?

This distinction also protects against a naive efficiency logic. Not all friction should be removed. But no burden should be able to function as hidden rationing without being made democratically and economically legible.

26.3 Audit, Armour, and State Legibility

Michael Power's analysis of the *audit society* shows how demands for control and accountability can create ever more rituals of verification. The organisation begins to shape work around what can be made auditable, even when the audit trail represents the actual task only partially.

This is the research neighbour of the report's image of **documentation as armour**. Documentation can protect rights, shared memory, and reviewability. But when responsibility and trust are weak, more documentation can also make real responsibility less visible and shift attention from the task to proof that the procedure was followed.

James C. Scott's *Seeing Like a State* adds a related warning. States and large organisations need to make society legible through categories, maps, standards, and registers. But schematic images can destroy or overlook the local interdependencies and practical knowledge — *mētis* — that make reality work.

Report 01's 13×13 section and *Knowing From the Ground* stand in this tradition, but add a stronger data boundary:

> What is not registered is not necessarily absent. And an absence of data is not automatically an empty space that the institution has a right to fill.

A blank response may be legitimate. A relational or bodily condition may be important without having to be transformed into shared data. Institutional sensing must therefore not be confused with total legibility.

26.4 Resilience Engineering and Green, Yellow, and Red Operations

The report's field reading has a close kinship with **resilience engineering** and the Safety-II tradition, particularly the work of Erik Hollnagel.

Here, safety and robust functioning are understood not only as the absence of error. A complex system must also be able to function under both expected and unexpected conditions. This requires the capacity to respond, monitor, learn, and anticipate. The research therefore investigates not only why something goes wrong, but how ordinary work succeeds every day through local adaptation.

Report 01's green, yellow, and red operations share the same foundational intuition:

- Green operations are not the absence of pressure, but preserved capacity to respond and correct.
- Yellow operations show growing dependence on compensation and hidden adaptation.
- Red operations show that formal functioning is maintained by consuming people, relationships, rights, or future capacity.

The report extends resilience engineering in three ways.

First, it makes municipal economics part of robustness. Capacity concerns not only technical and organisational adaptation, but the service-expenditure ceiling, capital, transfers, liquidity, and the political distribution of time and attention.

Second, it makes democratic and legal correction part of the field's carrying capacity. A system is not green merely because it continues to produce. The citizen must be able to understand, contest, and have an error repaired.

Third, it asks whether adaptation itself has become extractive. A system may be operationally resilient because particular people constantly compensate. It is not regenerative capacity if the field survives by slowly degrading its bearers.

26.5 Field Care and a Democratic Economy of Care

Joan Tronto's ethics of care provides a relevant but delimited analytical starting point. Care can be understood as more than a private feeling or a particular professional service: who notices needs, takes responsibility, performs the work, and bears the burdens is also an institutional and democratic question. Report 01 does not adopt Tronto's broader political programme, but uses this point to clarify care as public capacity rather than private virtue.

Field care directs attention towards the municipal work field as a whole.

Caring for the field does not mean protecting the organisation from criticism or avoiding every load. It means safeguarding the conditions under which the public task can continue to be performed with:

- professional and moral judgement;

- relational continuity;
- legal and democratic correctability;
- economic carrying capacity;
- the possibility of stopping, repair, and regeneration.

Field care is distributed. It may begin with a citizen, an employee, a manager, a colleague, a relative, a professional specialist, or a local actor who discovers that something is entering red operations. None of them is infallible. None should stand alone with the responsibility.

The decisive question is therefore whether signals of yellow or red operations can be received, tested, and lead to legitimate action.

Local Democratic Correction: Participation Is Not Automatically Democratisation

Ulrik Kjær's research on municipal politics and local democracy sharpens this dimension. In the essay *Kommunal politik uden stemmebokse?* (*Municipal Politics Without Ballot Boxes?*), he distinguishes between a thin and a thick version of representative democracy and examines the many municipal forms of participation between elections: citizen panels, citizens' assemblies, consultations, local councils, participatory budgets, local referendums, and committees established under section 17(4) of the Danish Local Government Act. The point is not that more participation automatically creates better democracy. Different forms distribute listening, conversation, collaboration, agenda-setting power, and responsibility in different ways (Kjær 2024).

Kjær, Niels Opstrup, and Mette Kjærgaard Thomsen's nationwide study of section 17(4) committees shows that 79 per cent of municipalities had established at least one such committee and that approximately two out of three committees met their two criteria for co-creation potential: participation by external non-public actors and a policy-development purpose. Municipalities associated these committees particularly with responsiveness, a better knowledge base, and new solutions — much less with budget savings. The study documents potential and purpose, however, not that the gains are actually realised. It also warns that responsiveness and influence may accrue to a small number of specially selected or privileged interests rather than to the many (Kjær, Opstrup, and Thomsen 2021).

This is directly relevant to Report 01's democratic feedback loops. **Involvement is not in itself legitimacy.** A citizen-facing correction architecture must make visible:

- who is invited and who is absent;
- how participants were selected;
- what mandate they have;
- who still holds decision-making authority;
- how disagreement and minority positions are registered;
- whether input actually changes the analysis or decision;
- and where political accountability ultimately lies.

Participation should expand the municipality's institutional sensing without dissolving representative responsibility or turning the citizen into unpaid labour.

A more recent study of 1,002 municipal election manifestos from all 98 municipalities finds both geographical variation within the same parties and political variation between parties in the individual municipality. In the authors' cautious formulation, local politics remains *at least partly local* (Florczak et al. 2026). This supports the report's use of local initial states and different municipal landscapes: a field intervention cannot be copied as a neutral standard template. Local variation does not, however, abolish shared rights, documentation requirements, or democratic responsibility.

The particular risk of placing responsibility on the nearest employee in AI-assisted work is addressed in the next section.

26.6 AI, Productivity, and the Moral Deformation Zone

Madeleine Clare Elish has used the concept of the **moral crumple zone** to show how the nearest human being in a complex automated system can come to absorb responsibility for errors even though that person had only limited control over the system's design and actions.

The critique is directly relevant to the Last Impulse, which the main report places as a local expression of distributed field care.

If an employee can formally press stop but lacks time, information, technical insight, managerial support, or a usable alternative route, meaningful human control has not been established. A responsibility surface has been established.

The Last Impulse must therefore never be designed as the solitary final operator expected to make a complex architecture ethical through a single click. It is legitimate when embedded in distributed field care and supported by:

- real decision-making authority;
- access to the relevant basis;
- time to investigate;
- collegial and professional contestation;
- a non-punitive correction route;
- an actual alternative work process;
- responsibility resting with the people and institutions that procured, configured, and managed the system.

Without these conditions, the Last Human Impulse risks becoming a moral crumple zone that protects the technology and the organisation by placing blame on the nearest employee.

At the same time, the report must not reduce AI to risk. Empirical research shows that generative AI can create significant productivity gains in particular work fields. Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond, for example, found higher task resolution per hour in a large customer-service field, but also significant variation between employees and a slight decline in quality among some of the most experienced. The result documents a real possibility; it does not document a general municipal savings percentage.

Report 01's particular contribution therefore lies not in denying the saving, but in asking what happens to it.

A documented AI gain can be used for:

- budget reduction;
- higher production requirements;
- managing backlogs;
- better quality;
- prevention;
- relational continuity;
- recovery and retention;
- or new political room for action.

Only when the use is decided visibly and legitimately can the productivity gain be described as **regenerative economic care**.

If all released time is immediately converted into more tasks, AI becomes a machine of intensification. If part of the gain returns to the field as attention, maintenance, relationship, competence, and correction capacity, AI can help move work from red or yellow towards greener operations.

26.7 The Report's Particular Contribution and Limitation

In relation to these research fields, Report 01's particular contribution is not one single new concept. It is the connection between several analyses that are otherwise separate:

1. Frontline judgement and coping are read as properties of the entire work field, not only of the individual.
2. Administrative burden is followed through municipal economics, citizen time, relationships, bodies, commons, and future budgets.
3. Robustness is assessed not only as continued functioning, but as preserved legal, democratic, and regenerative capacity.
4. AI productivity is linked to an explicit decision about the distribution and reinvestment of the gain.
5. Local democratic feedback is treated as an institutional architecture in which selection, mandate, power, and accountability must remain visible.
6. Care is treated as institutional and economic practice, not only as a human virtue.

It is here that the nature proposition must carry analytical weight.

Nature in this report does not mean idyllic balance. It means interdependence, rhythm, boundaries, thresholds, variation, exhaustion, repair, and the possibility of regeneration. If these dynamics are removed, the municipality's outputs can still be counted while its future capacity disappears.

The report offers no guarantee against this. It offers guidance, a language, and some practical tests:

- Can the field still sense when it enters yellow or red operations?
- Can the signal reach someone who can genuinely act?
- Does the economy protect the field's future capacity?
- Can a technical gain become human and public value?

- Can people err, correct, and begin again without one person being made a hero or scapegoat?

This is the report's research and practical position: not a flawless paradigm, but a discipline for caring for the field where the state meets life.

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